SATURDAY
October 3, 2026

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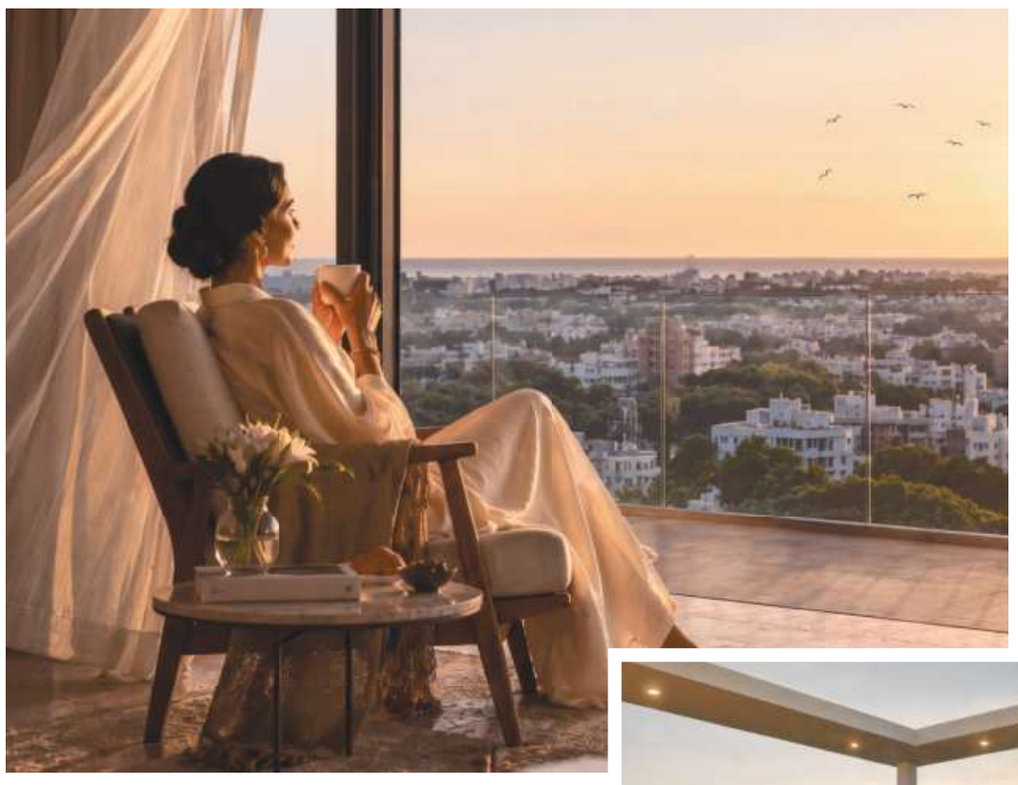
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CAPTAIN SMIT SPEAKS TO PM

'Used every bit of energy to save lives'

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Indian women's hockey team wins gold, seals LA 2028 berth

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NEW HOME

Buxa Tiger Reserve gets first tiger in years

NEWS » PAGE 10

A NEW TEMPLATE

India's Model BIT a decade later

A clearer, more workable framework for future treaty negotiations

EDITORIAL » PAGE 8



CALL FOR CHANGE

Pargat Singh appointed Punjab Congress chief

NEWS » PAGE 10

NEARBY



Stalin accuses CM of 'murdering democracy'

DHARAPURAM
DMK president M.K. Stalin on Friday said 'actor' CM C. Joseph Vijay has turned a 'villain' by imposing byelection through indulging in "horse-trading" and "murdering democracy". » PAGE 6

Two engineers suspended over Hindi signage

CHENNAI
Amid criticism over Hindi signage found on a Highways signboard, the government on Friday said it had suspended two engineers responsible for the "unauthorised Hindi inscriptions". » PAGE 6

METROPLUS WEEKEND » 4 PAGES
PROPERTYPLUS » 8 PAGES

Youth, leaders detained amid protest against CEC

Opposition parties, activists, and student groups protest across various States seeking Gyanesh Kumar's resignation; hundreds detained in Delhi; Rahul Gandhi condemns the police action

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Opposition parties, civil society activists, youth and student organisations held protests across the country on Friday demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar.

In Mumbai, the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP)-led protests at Shivaji Park received support from actors and artists. In Delhi, the police detained over 500 people, including former Chief Minister Atishi.

The Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, condemned the police action against the protesters and said hundreds are in custody. "Their only crime is that they dared to question vote theft," he said.



Protest against CEC Gyanesh Kumar near Jantar Mantar, in New Delhi, on Friday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Thousands joined the protests on Gandhi Jayanti, demanding Mr. Kumar's resignation. "Bapu taught us exactly this – speak the truth, fight peacefully. And that's what scares this government the most. A lathi can stop a crowd, but not a question. Gyanesh Kumar will go. And the system that put him there will go too," Mr. Gandhi said.

CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke announced that if Mr. Kumar does not resign, "cockroaches from across India" will protest at Jantar Mantar on October 10. All India Students' Association national president Neha Bora has called for a fresh protest at 1 p.m. on Saturday, saying, "Jantar Mantar 2.0 is not done! It has just begun."

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» PAGES 9 & 11
EDITORIAL
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EC asks States to enrol voters left out in SIR

NEW DELHI
The Election Commission has directed States and Union Territories where the special intensive revision (SIR) has been completed or is under way to identify eligible voters left out of the current rolls and facilitate their enrolment within a month. » PAGE 11

Trade deal with India is not 'imminent', says U.S. official after talks

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

While negotiations on an India-United States trade deal are nearing the end, the deal itself is not "imminent", U.S. Trade Representative Jamieson Greer indicated on Friday. His comments followed a "constructive conversation" with Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal in the U.S. on the sidelines of the G20 Trade Ministerial conference.

"We had a very constructive conversation, Minister Goyal and myself," Mr. Greer said at a press conference. "Our staff is meeting right now, since they are in the country and we are here. We are continually trying to finish the trade deal with India."

"I would characterise it, as we say in the U.S., we're in the short strokes," he added. "So I think we're toward the end of it. At the same time, I don't think there's something imminent." Mr. Greer said that the two sides had identified the "universe of items" that are sticking points for both sides and are "working diligently" to address them. He added that U.S. President Donald Trump and Prime Minister Narendra Modi had a "constructive call" on Wednesday, and said that there may be another call between the two leaders "very soon" to assess progress on the deal.



Jamieson Greer

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

CM launches expanded free bus travel for women in T.N.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Friday launched the 'Vettri Payanam' scheme, expanding no-fare bus travel for women and transpersons, at the Koyambedu bus terminus in Chennai. Mr. Vijay kick-started the scheme, coinciding with Gandhi Jayanthi, by issuing free tickets to women passengers.

The scheme will benefit 84.32 lakh beneficiaries every day. It is an expansion of the five-year-old 'Magalir Vidiyal Payanam' scheme. Under the expanded scheme, women can travel without paying fares on ordinary, express, limited stop service (LSS), and deluxe buses in cities and towns, ordinary buses in the mofussil areas, and ordinary buses in the ghat sections beyond 40 km.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 6

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INBRIEF



V. UMESH KUMAR

CJP stages protest in Chennai demanding CEC's resignation

As part of its countrywide agitation, the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) staged a protest in Chennai on Friday, demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar. Speaking to reporters, CJP State coordinator Selva Karthik said the protest was against the "corrupt and illegal actions" of the CEC. While voting rights were enshrined in the Constitution, a situation had emerged wherein those rights might be taken away, he alleged. "There is a mindset that it is not really an issue facing Tamil Nadu and therefore, it is not true," he said. In the 2026 Assembly election, over 12 lakh voters were removed, and the victory margin was less than 5,000 votes in 46 constituencies, he said. "If they appeal, about 20 lakh people could still be back on the rolls," he added.

Study identifies 148 out-of-school children in Ezhil Nagar; flags gaps in counselling support

Of them, 82 have been out of school for over a year, the assessment by Information and Resource Centre for Deprived Urban Communities says; it attributes educational exclusion to lack of essential documents, learning difficulties, distance from schools, and substance dependency in families

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

An assessment by the Information and Resource Centre for the Deprived Urban Communities (IRCDUC) has identified 148 out-of-school children in Ezhil Nagar – a resettlement site near Kannagi Nagar – nearly half of whom had remained out of school for one to three years.

The IRCDUC began working with children and families in the settlement in June 2024. It identified 99 out-of-school children in March 2025. By September 2026, the number had risen to 148 – 81 boys and 67 girls. The organisation attributed educational exclusion to multiple factors, including lack of essential documents, learning difficulties, distance from schools, inadequate availability of higher secondary schools, and substance dependency within families, a report by the IRCDUC notes.



Domestic hurdles: The assessment also records vulnerabilities such as single-parent households and family disputes. FILE PHOTO

Adolescents accounted for the bulk of those identified. A total of 110 children (74.3%) were aged between 11 and 18. Of them, 60 were in the 16-18 age group, while 50 were aged 11-15.

The assessment also found that educational exclusion was often prolonged. Information on the duration of absence was available for 122 children. Of these, 71 had been out of school for one to three years and another 11 for three years or more.

The IRCDUC said its interventions included helping children re-enter school, facilitating access to documents, and following up with schools and government departments. However, gaps remain.

A proposal to upgrade the Ezhil Nagar middle school to higher secondary is pending, while bridge-school arrangements and dedicated counselling support remain inadequate, the report said.

The current status assessment found that 23 children were enrolled in school regularly, while 15 were enrolled but attending irregularly. Ten children had returned to school but were out of school again. Another 37 were not interested in returning to school.

The assessment also recorded vulnerabilities, including tobacco use or dependency, single-parent households, family disputes, and substance use or dependency involving drugs or alcohol.

IRCDUC founder Vanessa Peter said that simply enrolling children in school without addressing their underlying vulnerabilities would not tackle the root causes and could result in them dropping out again. "Constant follow-ups and re-enrolment are needed. There should also be a community-based rehabilitation policy for children," she said.

Meanwhile, a field study by students at the Madras School of Social Work identified 19 out-of-school children and youth in Blocks 1 to 8 of Ezhil Nagar.

The survey found that lack of interest in studies was the most frequently reported reason for discontinuing education, accounting for eight cases. Family-related issues accounted for six cases, while three children had dropped out after failing Class 10 and subsequently lost interest in studies. Documentation problems and lack of specialised educational support accounted for one case each.

Chennai Port launches digitised tracking of export containers

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Chennai Port Authority recently launched 'Port Setu' to digitise the tracking of export container movement from Container Freight Station (CFS) to Chennai Port.

The system was developed by the National Association of Container Freight Stations (NACFS), Chennai Chapter, under the One Nation One Port Process initiative. This is the first phase of the Intelligent Vehicle Monitoring System (IVMS), which monitors vehicle movement using Automatic Number Plate Recognition, Optical Character Recognition, RFID readers, and software integration, including Customs' ICEGATE.



The Chennai Port Authority launches the first phase of the Intelligent Vehicle Monitoring System.

The primary advantages of 'Port Setu' include digitally recording the transit time of export containers and analysing their actual movements and ground realities, according to a press release. "It provides a common platform for Chennai Customs, Chennai Port Authority, and CFSs to monitor export container movement from CFS Gate-Out to Chennai Port entry and validate transit times against the Customs-prescribed timelines," it said.

When the second phase of the IVMS is implemented, gate-entry processes at the port will become completely digital. Sachin S. Kurve, Chairperson, Chennai Port Authority, said 'Port Setu', implemented by NACFS (Chennai Chapter), will offer better visibility of container movement and help CFSs to optimise trailer management.

M. Periasamy, Commissioner of Customs (Preventive), Chennai Customs, said trailer movement would be streamlined through the digitalisation and automation of procedures, helping Chennai Customs ensure compliance with prescribed procedures.

2 held for assaulting man, extorting cash after befriending him

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Ramapuram police arrested two men for allegedly assaulting a 27-year-old man at his house and extorting ₹1,300 from him after meeting him through Grindr, a social networking and dating app.

The accused were identified as Manikandan, 26, of Mugalivakkam, and Jitheshkannan, 25, of Alapakkam.

Mobile phone seized

The police seized a mobile phone and a two-wheeler allegedly used by them.

According to the police, the complainant, Dillibabu, 27, of Ramapuram, had befriended Manikandan through Grindr. On the night of September 29, Manikandan and Jitheshkannan allegedly visited Dillibabu's house, abused and assaulted him, and threatened him to send them ₹1,300 through GPay.

The next day, Dillibabu sent abusive messages to Jitheshkannan. That night, the duo allegedly returned to his house, assaulted him, and threatened him before fleeing on a two-wheeler, according to the police.

Based on Dillibabu's complaint, the Ramapuram police arrested the two men on Thursday.

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GAJÂANANDA Media

INBRIEF



T.N. Governor inaugurates Khadi rebate sales in the city

Tamil Nadu Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar inaugurated the Khadi rebate sales organised at Khadi Gramodyog Bhavan, Anna Salai, on Friday. Mr. Arlekar highlighted the relevance of Mahatma Gandhi's ideals of Swadeshi, self-reliance, and dignity of labour in the current era. He also emphasised the importance of promoting Khadi and indigenous products.

Spotlight
Read longform articles from our regional editions

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48% of tunnelling completed for Metro Rail's Phase 2 project

Three tunnel boring machines completed drilling on various stretches over the past three days; on Chetpet-KMC stretch, the machine drilled a distance of 685 metres under five railway tracks

TRACK TALES

Sunitha Sekar
CHENNAI

Nearly 48% of tunnelling for the underground network of Chennai Metro Rail Limited's (CMRL) 118.9-km Phase 2 project has been completed so far. In the last three days, three tunnel boring machines (TBMs) completed drilling on various stretches and made breakthroughs.

According to officials of CMRL, the project has 69.05 km of underground stretches spread over the three corridors – Madhavaram to SIPCOT (corridor 3), Poonamallee to Light House (corridor 4), and Madhavaram to Sholinganallur (corridor 5). Of this, tunnelling on 33.22 km has been completed so far.

In the Phase 2 project, corridor 3 has the longest distance of underground stretch at 43.04 km, and tunnelling on 22.63 km has been completed. While about 62% of tunnelling work has been done so far on corridor 4, CMRL has carried out 27% of the work on corridor 5.



Crucial links: According to officials of Chennai Metro Rail Limited, the 118.9-km Phase 2 project has 69.05 km of underground stretches spread over its three corridors. M. SRINATH

In the past three days, tunnelling has been completed on the Chetpet-Kilpauk Medical College (KMC), Villivakkam Railway Station-Villivakkam Bus Terminus, and Royapettah-Radhakrishnan Salai stretches.

On the Chetpet-KMC stretch, the machine bored a distance of 685 metres under five railway tracks near the Chetpet station, under the Chetpet Eco Park, and the KMC Hospital.

The machine also drilled 6.1 metres below the Phase 1 tunnel.

On the Villivakkam Railway Station-Villivakkam Bus Terminus stretch, the tunnelling distance was 601 metres, and on this section too, the TBM had to bore under five railway tracks of the Villivakkam station.

The TBM, which drilled on the Royapettah-Radhakrishnan Salai stretch covered a distance of 915 metres, and it went under many structures on Royapettah High Road, including Peters Bridge, the EPFO building, and a school.

Tamil Nadu recording around 200 dengue cases a day; numbers remain steady: DPH

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu is recording around 200 cases of dengue a day. Fresh cases are being reported in places including Chennai and its neighbouring districts and cities such as Coimbatore and Madurai.

Officials of the Directorate of Public Health (DPH) and Preventive Medicine said the caseload remained steady and was not of outbreak proportions. A. Somasundaram, Director of Public Health and Preventive Medicine, said cases had not risen exponentially, with the numbers remaining broadly steady. "We are seeing nearly 200 cases a day. The numbers are not doubling or tripling, which usually happens in an outbreak. Right now, there is a static trend in the number of dengue cases, and we are expecting the cases to decline soon," he said.

Cases are being reported across cities including the Chennai belt (Tiruvallur and Kancheepuram), Coimbatore, and Madurai. This could partly be due to a "natural bias" with these areas having more hospitals and testing facilities, Dr. Somasundaram said.

"We have specifically instructed staff to increase the number of tests for dengue for better surveillance and patient management... We don't want to miss a case, and when samples are tested, we can identify pockets of cases or clusters, which are likely to bring about an outbreak," he said. There are over 4,500 government and private laboratories in the State, he added. Surveillance measures to identify *Aedes* mosquito breeding pools are continuing, but the number of pools detected has started to decline as a result of source reduction measures. The mosquito density is slowly falling, he said.

Dr. Somasundaram said while preventive measures had been intensified, they had been holding daily monitoring meetings with District Health Officers via video conferencing.

Timings
CHENNAI

SATURDAY, OCT. 03		
RISE	05:59	SET 17:58
RISE	23:53	SET 12:17
SUNDAY, OCT. 04		
RISE	05:59	SET 17:57
RISE	00:00	SET 13:15
MONDAY, OCT. 05		
RISE	05:59	SET 17:57
RISE	00:56	SET 14:07

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	35	24
Chennai Airport	35	27
Chennai City	34	26

Chennai Airport Today
37°C The weather will be dry. Day will be very warm and uneasy. Night also will be uneasy.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
38°C The weather will be dry. Day will be slightly hot and uneasy. Night will be comfortable.

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THE HINDU
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State Cabinet should comprise 50% women Ministers, says Annamalai

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Former BJP leader K. Annamalai, who has floated the 'We The Leaders' movement, on Friday said women should constitute half of the State Cabinet. He was addressing an event where he presented the Kamarajar Awards to 10 women from across Tamil Nadu at Narada Gana Sabha in Chennai.

While appreciating the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam-led government for giving Cabinet berths to more women than previous governments, Mr. Annamalai said he aspired to form a Cabinet with 50% women when his movement came to power.

Sister Rosily (from Kanniyakumari district); founder-trustee of Alert NGO Kala Balasundaram (Coimbatore district); mountaineer Muthamilselvi Narayanan (Virudhunagar district); information technology professional-turned organic farmer Jeevitha (Cuddalore district); Villupattu artiste M. Madhavi (Tenkasi district); founder of Popular's Sevak Trust A. Fathima (Tirunelveli district); student-palmyra tree climber P. Harris Karishma (Villupuram district); Carnatic classical violinist C.S. Chinmayi (Chennai); yoga instructor R. Punitha Valli (Chennai); and aerospace engineering student Dhaanvi Karthikeyan (Chennai) were presented the awards.



'We The Leaders' founder K. Annamalai presenting Kamarajar Awards at the event in Chennai on Friday. V. UMESH KUMAR

P. Krishnaveni, former president of the Thalaiyuthu panchayat in Tirunelveli district from the Dalit community, who was brutally attacked by a gang, was chosen to receive the WTL's Kamarajar Award. However, as she could not receive it in person, she had sent a recorded video message.

During his speech, Mr. Annamalai said initially there was only one woman in the Cabinet and it had gradually increased. "There should be at least 17-18 women in the State Cabinet," he said, adding that an all-women team was set to be trained in his Kalam Centre on October 15. Mr. Annamalai underlined the significance of training women for politics.

Special drive for voter enrolment

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Election Commission of India (EC) has planned to conduct a special drive for the enrolment of left-out and young/first-time eligible electors under the process of continuous updation of electoral rolls in States and Union Territories where the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) has already been completed.

According to a press release from Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Archana Patnaik, the Declaration Form attached with Form 6 will be used during the SIR phase only.

For the non-SIR period, the forms applicable under the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, will be utilised.

Chola-era inscription found during pond restoration in Medavakkam

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

What began as an effort by residents to restore a pond in Medavakkam took an unexpected turn when a Chola-era stone inscription was discovered in the lakebed.

Residents recalled that Nalla Thanneer Kulam near Pillaiyar Koil Street was a drinking water source for the locality until about three decades ago. It still remains largely unpolluted and a freshwater source. Like many other waterbodies being restored with support from non-governmental organisations (NGOs), residents sought to clean the waterbody with the aid of Rotary Club of Chennai Mid City and Yatha Green Council of India.

Residents found the 13th Century CE stone inscription during the desilting exercise, offering a glimpse into the locality's past. Arjun Shankar, a Medavakkam resident, said people from various parts of Medavakkam used to source drinking water from the pond until a few decades ago.

The pond is near Medavakkam Sitheri, which is in dire need for restoration, and falls under the St. Thomas Mount block development office.

A team of officials from the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) recently inspected the site to examine the inscription and have taken records of the inscription, including paper impressions, to assess its historical significance. According to the experts, the inscription has recorded the construction of a sluice in the ancient Monapakkam lake. Tamil scholar Ma. Poongundran said the inscriptions were deciphered along with senior epigraphist S. Rajavelu.



Preserving the past: Officials from the Archaeological Survey of India making a paper impression of the inscription found in the Nalla Thanneer Kulam in Medavakkam. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Dated to 13th Century

The inscription, dating back to 1268 CE, was created during the rule of the Telugu Chola king Vijaya Ganda Gopalan, who reigned in Kancheepuram. The inscription has documented that a merchant of Monappakkam installed the sluice then. Monapakkam later came to be known as Modavakkam, Mr. Poongundran said.

The inscription is an indication that several waterbodies were created for agricultural and drinking water needs around Chennai over the centuries. The Nalla Thanneer Kulam could have been part of a huge waterbody, he added.

Residents sought the installation of the inscription near the pond along with an explanatory display highlighting its historical significance.

SI, constable suspended on graft charges

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A Sub-Inspector and constable attached to the North Beach police station have been placed under suspension for allegedly accepting a ₹10,000 bribe to release a stolen two-wheeler.

The complaint said a man from Sivaganga district had reported the theft of his two-wheeler in Tiruppur. After he lodged a complaint, Vivek, the constable, contacted him and informed him that his two-wheeler had been traced to Chennai and asked him to come to the city.

The complainant visited the police station on September 28. He alleged that Sub-Inspector Sivaraj and Vivek demanded money from him before releasing the two-wheeler. Following an inquiry by the Internal Vigilance Cell of the Greater Chennai Police, the two were suspended. Further action is under way.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

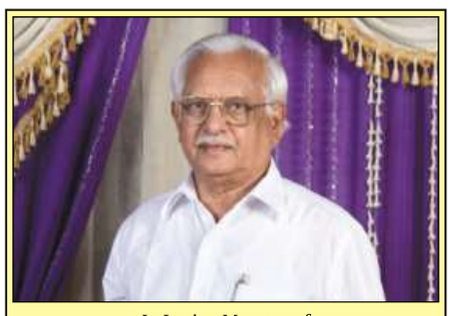
DEATH

Smt. RAJAM JOSEPH (81), Mother of Ms. Lourdhu Rexi Joseph, Chennai - 600015, expired on 01.10.2026, Eyes donated to Rotary Rajan Eye Bank (Project of Rotary Club of Madras T.Nagar), Chennai- 17 (Ph: 28340500).

SMT S Mangalam 88yrs attained Sivalogaprapthi on 02.10.2026 @ our residence 6, Krishna Komala Apartments, 45 Thambiah Rd, West Mambalam, Ch–33 Creamation on 03–10–2026 by 10am @ Kannamapettai Burial Ground, T Nagar. Sons:S Venkatakrishnan & S Venkatesan :98404 55358/ 96000 76633

P.K. DEVIDAS (Puthusseri Kollaikal) , 87, former GM, Jet Air, South India passed away in Palakkad on 20 September 2026 after a brief illness. An airline professional since 1959, he held senior positions with Indian Airlines, Swissair, British Airways (Riyadh), Gulf Air – GSA Jetair and Universal Aviation. He is survived by his siblings Prema M. Singh, P.K. Sudarsan and Dr. P.K. Krishnakumar. His wife Agnes, son Dinesh Devidas and sister Umadevi S. Nair predeceased him. 15th Day Ceremony: 3 October 2026 at 5 Murthy Temple, Palakkad District, Kerala.

DEATH



In Loving Memory of
GULLAPALLI NAGESWARA RAO (88)
Vastu Consultant
With deep sorrow, we inform the demise of our beloved father on 30th September 2026.
The Final Rites will be held on Sat, 3rd October 2026
Final Respects:
8 –11 a.m. Venue: 11 Landons Road, Kilpauk, Chennai.
Cremation: after 1 p.m. at Velangadu Burial Ground, Near RTO Office, Anna Nagar East, Chennai - 600102.
Family Members
Ph: 98412-73317

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES



Dr. CHAVALY MANI SASTRY
February 25, 1938 - October 1, 2026
Fondly remembered by her Family and Friends.
Chavaly Venkatesh and Chavaly Shailashree
Gajjala Shailaja & Gajjala Nagendra
Sundaram
Sharmila Chavaly
Kirti Bhushan and Soujanya
Kartikeya and Akanksha
Krittika
Keerthana
Ira
Vedansh

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

"Those who walk uprightly enter into peace; they find rest as they lie in death" – Isaiah 57:2
REMEMBRANCE



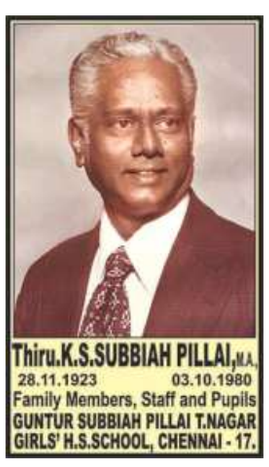
M. THEODORE ROBERT
Thomas Marine & Automation Services
24.08.1968 – 03.10.2022
You will always be part of us in our hearts, we will miss you and remember you in every moment of our life
Deeply remembered by
wife Anita Roberts and Family Members

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

14th DEATH ANNIVERSARY



K. Thyagarajan T.Manjula
Recollection of Sorrow is still more sorrow
Fondly Remembered by
All Family Members



DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

SECOND ANNIVERSARY



T.AYYASWAMI
Ex General Secretary,
Grindiays Bank Employees union,
Fondly remembered by
Son : Jagannath & Family U.S.A
jayyaswami@yahoo.com
Daughter:
Sujatha Ranganathan & Family Canada
Sujatharanganathan93@gmail.com
Brothers & Sister & their Families.

IN MEMORY OF YOUR LOVED ONES
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ISSN 0971 - 751X

Accused in multiple cases shot in leg by police during arrest

Tambaram police say they fired at Sadam Hussain in self-defence after he attacked a police officer with a machete when officers tried to arrest him

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tambaram police shot a wanted history-sheeter in his leg before arresting him in Karasangal forest area in the early hours of Friday.

The accused, Sadam Hussain, is reportedly facing more than 20 criminal cases across several police stations, with two court warrants pending against him.

The police said he had been absconding for a long time and was allegedly involved in peddling ganja.

According to the police, Hussain attacked a police officer with a machete when officers tried to arrest him.



Weapons seized: Four country-made bombs, three machetes, and more than 20 kg of ganja that the police seized from Sadam Hussain (inset), the accused. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The police claimed that they fired at his leg in self-defence and apprehended him.

Officers recovered four country-made bombs, three machetes, and more than 20 kg of ganja from him, the police said.

The incident occurred within the jurisdiction of the Manimangalam police station in the Tambaram City Police limits.

Two brothers found dead at Periamet lodge

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Two brothers from Virudhunagar district were found dead at a lodge in Periamet on Thursday night.

The deceased were identified as Karthik Raja, 28, and his younger brother Vinoth, 21, sons of Raj, of Rosapatti in Virudhunagar district. The brothers had checked into the lodge on Tuesday. They told the lodge staff that they had come to the city to attend an examination. According to police, lodge employee Subramani noticed that the brothers had not left the room since checking in.

On being alerted about foul smell from their room, the police broke open the door and found the brothers dead.

(Assistance for overcoming suicidal thoughts is available on the State's health helpline 104, Tele-MANAS 14416 and Sneha's suicide prevention helpline 044-24640050)

Man arrested by Crime Branch for robbery in T. Nagar, two juveniles questioned

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 19-year-old youth was arrested, and two juveniles were produced before the Juvenile Justice Board in connection with a robbery in T. Nagar, in which a man was allegedly assaulted and robbed of cash and AirPods.

The police said Rohanraj, 19, a native of West Bengal, was working at a star hotel in T. Nagar and staying at a hostel nearby. On September 11, after completing his work around midnight, he was walking along Rajamannar Street, when three unidentified persons intercepted and assaulted him. The trio allegedly snatched ₹1,500 from his pocket and his AirPods before fleeing.

Based on Rohanraj's complaint, the Pondy Bazaar Crime Branch Police registered a case and launched an investigation. On examining CCTV footage, the police arrested Pradeep, 19, of Thiru-Vi-Ka Quarters in Teynampet. The police also traced and questioned two juveniles, aged 13 and 17, in connection with the case.

Two held over attempt to grab ₹1-cr. property

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tambaram Central Crime Branch have arrested two men in connection with an attempt to fraudulently take over a property worth ₹1 crore in Arul Nagar, Guduvanchery. The police said that a case was registered on May 2 following a complaint by Ganesan, 82. G. Munusamy impersonated the complainant, while L. Sathyakumar helped register forged documents to facilitate the sale of the property. Munusamy and Sathyakumar were arrested and remanded in judicial custody. The police said further probe is on.

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T–45/5/2026–TS–IBM_HQ Date : 01/10/2026
NOTICE INVITING APPLICATIONS FOR REGISTRATION AS MINERAL EXCHANGE IN INDIA
Indian Bureau of Mines (IBM) invites sealed applications for the registration of companies meeting the Eligibility Criteria under Rule 6 of the Mineral Exchange Rules, 2026.
The Objective, Function, Eligibility, Fees and other details have been defined in the said rules notified by the Central Government on 30th June 2026. The Notice Inviting Applications (NIA) document seeking applications for registration as Mineral Exchange contains the bidding schedule, brief objective, scope of work, the eligibility criteria, procedure for filing application, grant of registration for establishing & operating the electronic platform for the Mineral Exchange etc.
The NIA document containing application form shall be available for download from **website www.ibm.gov.in on 03rd October 2026** and the last date of submission of Application is **02nd November 2026 up to 1500 hrs.**
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Sd
Controller of Mines
Mineral Exchange Cell, IBM

GOVERNMENT OF WEST BENGAL
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12th Floor 1, K. S. Roy Road, Kolkata-1
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From Page One

Vijay launches expanded free bus travel for women



All smiles: Women passengers at the launch of the 'Vettri Payanam' scheme in Chennai on Friday. R. RAGU

S. Malar, a resident of Chennai who was in one of the buses at Koyambedu, said, "It was pretty surreal and exciting to see the Chief Minister issue tickets to passengers."

K. Abhirami, a resident of Tiruvallur, was glad the scheme was being expanded. "I had the opportunity to even take a photograph with him [Mr. Vijay]," she said.

Over 12,000 buses included

A total of 12,695 buses under the seven State Transport Corporations have been brought under 'Vettri Payanam', and 1,68,500 trips (singles) will be operated.

The scheme will not be implemented in Chengalpattu and Tiruppur districts as the Model Code of Conduct is in force for the byelections to the Madurantakam and Dharapuram Assembly constituencies.

On August 24, Mr. Vijay announced the expanded scheme under Rule No. 110 in the Tamil Nadu Assembly.

INBRIEF

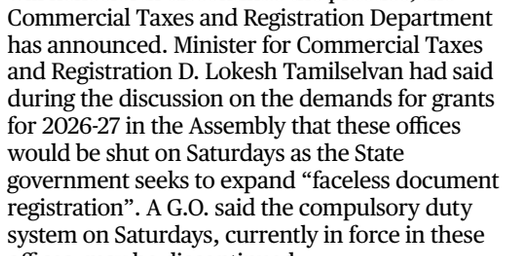


100 sub-registrar offices across State to be shut on Saturdays

As many as 100 sub-registrar offices in Tamil Nadu that have been functioning on Saturdays will henceforth discontinue the practice, the Commercial Taxes and Registration Department has announced. Minister for Commercial Taxes and Registration D. Lokesh Tamilselvan had said during the discussion on the demands for grants for 2026-27 in the Assembly that these offices would be shut on Saturdays as the State government seeks to expand "faceless document registration". A G.O. said the compulsory duty system on Saturdays, currently in force in these offices, may be discontinued.

Ex-Gem Granites staffer held for having Veeramani clip

The Central Crime Branch has arrested a former employee of Gem Granites for allegedly possessing a video purporting to show its founder R. Veeramani engaging in an obscene act with a minor girl, and failing to inform the police about it. Veeramani and his alleged accomplices Shanthi and Mahendra Simhan were arrested on August 29 and remanded in Puzhal Central Prison after a case was registered against them by the Central Crime Branch for paedophilia. The police said Ganesan, who had worked at Gem Granites for 23 years and is now employed at Balaji Global Enterprises, was arrested for possessing the video on his mobile phone.



CM lauds Asian Games bronze medallist Nethra Kumanan

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Friday congratulated Nethra Kumanan for bringing pride to Tamil Nadu and India by winning the bronze medal in the women's dinghy event in sailing at the Asian Games being held in Japan. He also announced that the State government will provide her a cash incentive of ₹30 lakh. "She has achieved this victory through her talent, hard work and dedication. The success of sailor Nethra Kumanan will provide new inspiration to the young sportspersons of Tamil Nadu. I wish her many more victories and new achievements in the future," he said.

In Dharapuram, AIADMK, DMK and TVK candidates are locked in a fierce contest

Leaders of the three parties are making last-minute outreach to the voters, even as Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, who covered the constituency once, is planning to visit it again on October 4

T. Ramakrishnan
DHARAPURAM

The Dharapuram Assembly constituency, which has 2.23 lakh electors and where a byelection is scheduled for October 6, is witnessing a fierce battle among three major parties: the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), and the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK).

"In all likelihood, this will be reflected in the outcome, regardless of the winner," says K.M. Ramasamy, a veteran farmer in the constituency. The three major parties' nominees are P. Sathyabama (TVK), who defected from the AIADMK after winning from the constituency in the April-May election; S. Suganya of the DMK; and K. Bhanumathi of the AIADMK. The Left has fielded P. Lakshmanan of the Communist Party of India (CPI) and the Naam Tamilar Katchi (NTK) has put up M. Karthika.

Leaders of the three parties are making last-minute outreach to the people, even as Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, who covered the constituency once, is planning to visit it again on October 4. Former Chief Ministers M.K. Stalin of the DMK and Edappadi K. Palaniswami of the AIADMK conducted roadshows on Friday. Mr. Palaniswami had visited the area twice. All the three parties have drafted many of their senior functionaries for the election work.

The TVK's campaign is being spearheaded by Revenue Minister K.A. Sengottaiyan, while the DMK and the AIADMK have entrusted the work to former Ministers, including Vellakoil M.P. Saminathan and Thangam Thennarasu, of the DMK, and Pollachi V. Jayaraman and Dindigul C. Sreenivasan, of the AIADMK. However, in contrast to the vibrant atmosphere that can be felt all the time at the offices of the TVK and the DMK on Dharapuram town's main road, the AIADMK's office wears a sober look.

Seat statistics

An overview of the Dharapuram Assembly constituency

ELECTORATE

Total **2,23,333**

Men **1,07,312**

Women **1,16,013**

Third gender **8**

- The constituency has been reserved for the Scheduled Castes since 1967
- The AIADMK and the DMK have won the seat seven times each. The Congress, the PMK, and an Independent have won it once each



M. PERIASAMY

First-time voters **4,640**

Persons with disabilities **1,344**

Electors aged 85 and above **2,658**

The TVK's campaign is being spearheaded by Revenue Minister K.A. Sengottaiyan, while DMK and AIADMK have entrusted the work to former Ministers

Dominant groups

Though Dharapuram has been set apart for the Scheduled Castes (SCs) since 1967, the Kongu Vellala Gounders, according to an estimate, constitute 42% of the population, followed by the SCs with 32%. Chettiars and Nadars account for 3.7% each, while the shares of Muslims and Christians are 4% and 1.8%.

The fledgling TVK, being the ruling party, enjoys goodwill among certain sections, especially women. But some volunteers of the party say that if the party had put up someone else instead of Ms. Sathyabama, there is no need for Mr. Vijay to campaign personally. They concede that their party's nominee did face hostile treatment in some villages because of her decision to seek re-election within such a short period on a "weak" ground. But Keerthana, a young homemaker of Manakadavu village, feels the ruling party deserves to be given a "fair chance" and the criticism that the government has not fulfilled many of the electoral promises does not hold water as every other party, which was in power till now, took its own time to implement its assurances.

The DMK, which represented the constituency during 2021-26, is contesting virtually single-handedly, as most of its allies have deserted it, and are backing the TVK. The Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK) is an exception, and its general secretary Premallatha Vijayakant was in the constituency a few days ago. However, the DMK is taking no chances. Its fieldwork has been acknowledged by a functionary of the AIADMK, who is from Coimbatore. "Our workers are working vigorously and the upset we suffered in the general election has only prompted them to work much more fiercely than what it would have been otherwise," says I.P. Senthilkumar, three-time legislator and son of the DMK's face in Dindigul district I. Periyasamy.

The AIADMK, which may appear to be weak, is no pushover as it continues to have considerable hold in the constituency, according to a cross-section of the people. A resident of the town, who is a mechanical engineer, says that traditionally, the DMK is stronger in urban areas and the AIADMK in the villages. The entry of the TVK has upset the applecart. Mr. Ramasamy, the farmer, says the ruling party appears to have grown at the cost of the AIADMK, something that the DMK feels will work to its advantage.

Mr. Jayaraman, the former Minister, says those who had voted for the TVK in the general election have started realising that the TVK does not mean what it had promised, and it cannot be taken seriously. "The AIADMK being the only credible alternative to the DMK, the voters will elect our candidate once again," he says.

"Irrespective of the party that is bagging the seat this time, the winner should take steps for resolving water shortage in our constituency where most of the farmland is rain-fed," says N. Natarajan, another farmer who lives near Dasanaickenpatti village. He adds that he has submitted a project proposal to Mr. Sengottaiyan for groundwater recharge.

Mr. Ramasamy points out that the farmers have been buying water for farming and feeding the cattle and the poultry. For 24,000 litres, they had paid ₹5,000 in the last three-four months, because of the failure of the Southwest monsoon, he recalls.

It remains to be seen whether the result, to be declared on October 9, will make a meaningful difference to the electors who struggle for water.



Blistering attack: DMK president M.K. Stalin campaigning for party candidate Suganya in Dharapuram on Friday. S. SIVA SARAVANAN

'Minority' TVK govt. has 'forced' bypoll for CM's selfish gain, says DMK president

R. Krishnamoorthy
DHARAPURAM

DMK president M.K. Stalin on Friday said "actor Chief Minister" C. Joseph Vijay, after playing a hero in *Jananayagan*, had turned a villain by imposing a byelection through "horse-trading" and "murder of democracy".

"I have come not just for votes, but also for justice from the electorate over the election being thrust on them by the Chief Minister, heading a 'minority government', for selfish gain," Mr. Stalin said, seeking votes for the DMK's candidate in the Dharapuram (Reserved) constituency, S. Suganya.

"The byelection is a waste of your tax money. The vote you had cast only months ago has been rendered infructuous," Mr. Stalin told a massive gathering, adding that now was the opportunity to teach a lesson [to the TVK] by choosing a trustworthy candidate. He also referred to TVK candidate Sathyabama's switch to the ruling party after resigning as an AIADMK MLA as a "somersault", while levelling horse-trading charges and making an oblique reference to her appearance.

On the other hand, he described Ms. Suganya, a lawyer by profession, as an articulate candidate who will lend voice to the causes of the people of Dharapuram effectively in the Assembly.

Addressing Mr. Vijay as 'CM Sir' and 'Bro', Mr. Stalin said the former had stopped acting in front of the camera, but was delivering 'yelling' performances in front of the people. Yet, media cameras were anathema to the Chief Minister, Mr. Stalin added.

The TVK was meek before the Election Commission of India (EC) over the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) due to "fear of the BJP", Mr. Stalin alleged, adding that the Chief Minister himself had admitted in his Dharapuram campaign speech that "the TVK was a branch of the BJP".

"Mr. Vijay has breached the decorum in the Assembly by making a mockery of my MISA incarceration," the DMK president said, calling upon Mr. Vijay to behave like a Chief Minister and not a 'Cheap Minister'.

The TVK was not a political party, but a corporate mafia bent on destroying Tamil Nadu, Mr. Stalin emphasised, while making specific references to the "surreptitious sale" of tickets for the consecration of the Arulmigu Meenakshi Sundareswarar Temple in Madurai, and the move to construct a new Assembly Complex at Pattinapakkam at a cost of ₹1,200 crore despite the State's financial situation.

Attacking the TVK government on law and order, Mr. Stalin claimed that informants on drug peddling were being murdered, and that sexual abuse, lock-up deaths, and honour killings had gone up. Industrial investments were taking a "U-turn" to Andhra Pradesh, he claimed.

Two highways officials suspended over use of Hindi on signboard

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The government said it will take action against officials who act contrary to the two-language policy

Amid criticism over Hindi signage found on a Highways signboard, the Tamil Nadu government on Friday said it had suspended the Assistant Executive Engineer and the Assistant Engineer responsible for the "unauthorised Hindi inscriptions" on the Nagercoil-Madurai State Highway (SH-93), pending further action. Departmental action had been initiated against them.

An official press release said the Hindi inscriptions on the signboard along the newly inaugurated road on the State Highway in Sattankulam had been removed. The State government will take appropriate action against officials who act contrary to the State's two-language policy, the release added.

Stalin criticises govt.

Earlier in the day, DMK president M.K. Stalin condemned the use of Hindi signage.

In a post on X, he said, "Until now, Tamil Nadu was facing Hindi imposition by the Union government. Now, the State government itself is doing it."

"Is this yet another attempt by the TVK government, which tests the waters in every issue and makes a 'U-turn' once opposition flares up," he asked. He emphasised that the two-language policy is Tamil Nadu's core principle and warned against "playing with it".

Public Works Department Minister Aadhav Arjuna said: "The two-language policy is a vital principle for the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam, too. Two officials responsible for this lapse were suspended yesterday (October 1). Moreover, the signboard written in three languages was replaced immediately with a new one written in two languages."

CM campaigns in Madurantakam with roadshow ahead of October 6 bypoll

Saptarshi Bhattacharya
CHENNAI

Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) president and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Friday held a massive roadshow in the Madurantakam (Reserved) Assembly constituency in Chengalpattu district, about 80 km from Chennai, where a byelection is scheduled for October 6.

Campaigning for TVK candidate Maragatham Kumaravel, Mr. Vijay began his roadshow at Mamandur on GST Road around 2.30 p.m. Fans and supporters flocked in large numbers along the entire route of the Chief Minister's cavalcade. In the course of his four-and-a-half-hour roadshow, Mr. Vijay traversed through 40 villages. His cavalcade passed through Karunguzhi, Ayyanar Temple Junction, Mocheri, Thandalam, Perumbakkam, Sempoondi, Elapakkam, Kil Athipakka, and Melmaruvathur Adiparasakthi Temple Junction, before culminating on Therady Street in Madurantakam.

Along the way, he stopped by to have tea at a shop and interacted with the locals at certain points.

Maragatham Kumaravel, elected from the constituency on an AIADMK ticket, resigned from the Assembly on May 25 and joined the TVK, less than a month after the Assembly election results were declared, thus necessitating the byelection.

Braving the heat

Unmindful of the hot and sultry conditions, fans and supporters of Mr. Vijay lined up along GST Road since the forenoon to catch a glimpse of their tinsel hero-turned-politician.

Perched atop his campaign van along with the TVK candidate, Mr. Vijay waved at his fans at every junction and received gifts and letters even as his supporters showered flowers on him. At Melavalampettai, supporters presented him with a spear, a sceptre, and a bronze statuette of Lord Murugan.

Mahalakshmi, a second-year BCA student, was among the large number of starry-eyed youngsters who had gathered along the route. Barely 18, she has just applied for inclusion in the electoral rolls, and will not be able to vote in the byelection. "I am here to catch a glimpse of him. I will perhaps vote for him next time after seeing his performance. But I have faith that he will do a good job," she said with a smile.

Also spotted among the crowd was Mohammed Moinul, a young tailor from West Bengal, standing with a TVK flag on one hand and his phone on the other. When asked what made him come there, he said, "Joyful frenzy".

While the entire stretch of GST Road, spanning Madurantakam, witnessed traffic congestion since the morning, the situation became acute during the roadshow. The police found it difficult to control the crowd, which took position along both sides of the road, slowing down traffic considerably. Though temporary metal barricades were put up all along the route, the supporters did not find it difficult to cross them. It took more than an hour for the congestion to clear even after the cavalcade passed a particular point.



Poll pitch: TVK president and Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay holding a roadshow in Madurantakam on Friday. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

INBRIEF



Bengaluru-Mumbai Vande Bharat may start this month

The Railway Board has approved the introduction of a Vande Bharat Sleeper Express between KSR Bengaluru and Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Terminus (CSMT), Mumbai, and is likely to start operations from this month, according to officials. The service is proposed to operate six days a week. The 16-coach train will have stoppages at Anantapur, Guntakal, Raichur, Kalaburagi, Solapur, Pune and Kalyan, in addition to its originating and terminating stations.

Another pre-printed Form 7 surfaces, fuels apprehensions

Apprehensions about a larger conspiracy behind the applications for bulk deletion of voters as part of the ongoing special intensive revision of electoral rolls found validation in another pre-printed Form 7 surfacing in Bahadurpura constituency in Telangana on Friday. The form, sourced from the Congress, appears ready to be filed, with the voter's name and his address printed, but the applicant's name is missing, which indicates that it was not submitted.

Multiple Indian payloads sent to orbit by Space X's Falcon 9

Multiple payloads developed by Indian firms were deployed in orbit by Space X's Falcon 9 on Friday from Space Launch Complex 4E (SLC-4E) at Vandenberg Space Force Base in California, U.S., as part of Transporter-18 rideshare mission. Dhruva Space's Launching Expeditions for Aspiring Payloads (LEAP-2), hosting multiple In-Orbit Demonstration (IOD) missions were part of the Transporter-18 mission.

BJP tells Karnataka CM to prove Form 7 charge or quit

Only 25,000 Form 7 applications filed in the State, not lakhs as the Chief Minister claims, says Karnataka BJP chief; party not afraid even if 1,000 FIRs are filed, will fight in court, he adds

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Karnataka BJP unit president B.Y. Vijayendra on Friday challenged the Chief Minister to resign if he fails to prove his allegation that the party misused Form 7 applications to seek the deletion of eligible voters from the electoral rolls.

"The Chief Minister should prove his allegations," he said. "We [BJP] will not be afraid even if 1,000 FIRs are filed against us. We will fight the cases in court," he said.

On Thursday, D.K. Shivakumar, with his Cabinet colleagues, protested in front of the Chief Electoral Officer's (CEO's) office in Bengaluru demanding an investigation into the filing of Form 7 applications in bulk seeking the deletion of voters, particularly from Muslim, Dalit, and backward-class communities. He alleged that 'pre-filled' forms containing voters' details had been submitted in several constituencies as part of a 'conspiracy' to remove eligible voters from the rolls.



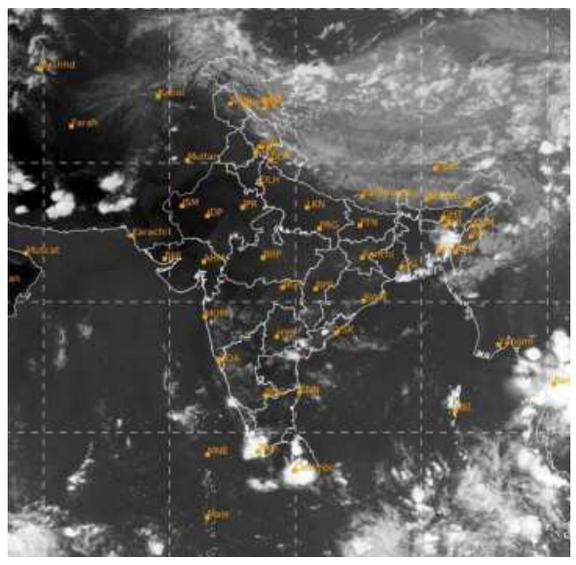
BJP leader R. Ashok and others condemned the protest by Congress leaders in front of the election officials' office. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Calling the protest a "staged drama", Mr. Vijayendra accused the Congress of shifting the blame onto the BJP instead of addressing reported irregularities. "Your party is running the government. Booth Level Officers are under your control," he said.

Mr. Vijayendra said only 25,000 Form 7 applications had been filed in Karnataka, not the lakhs the Chief Minister claimed were putting voters at risk. He said that Form 7 is a mechanism for seeking the removal of ineligible entries and its use by itself is not illegal. Leader of the Opposition R. Ashoka, along with other BJP leaders, met Police Commissioner Seemant Kumar Singh and sought an FIR against the Chief Minister and his Cabinet colleagues for their protest outside the CEO's office, arguing that protests were permitted only at Freedom Park.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Saturday: Heavy Rainfall likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh. Thunderstorm accompanied with lightning and gusty winds likely at isolated places over Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Karaikal. Thunderstorm accompanied with lightning likely at isolated places over Assam, Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram and Tripura

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	6.8	33.3	25.6	Kurnool	—	37.7	26.2
Ahmedabad	—	37.0	23.1	Lucknow	—	33.9	23.4
Aizawl	4.8	32.0	22.8	Madurai	6.6	37.0	25.6
Bengaluru	—	30.5	19.9	Mangaluru	2.7	33.2	24.0
Bhopal	—	34.0	18.0	Mumbai	—	37.4	27.5
Bhubaneswar	—	35.6	25.2	Mysuru	—	31.2	21.0
Chandigarh	—	33.6	23.9	New Delhi	—	36.0	22.3
Chennai	—	35.4	27.3	Patna	—	33.5	26.0
Coimbatore	—	34.6	24.6	Port Blair	9.4	31.5	25.6
Dehradun	—	27.7	24.0	Prayagraj	—	35.0	23.8
Gangtok	—	22.9	17.1	Puducherry	—	33.0	25.2
Goa	—	—	—	Pune	—	33.3	20.9
Guwahati	—	33.3	24.5	Raipur	—	34.0	25.2
Hubballi	—	33.0	22.0	Ranchi	—	30.2	19.0
Hyderabad	—	33.9	23.2	Shillong	0.1	23.6	15.4
Imphal	35.0	27.1	20.9	Shimla	—	26.5	16.6
Jaipur	—	36.2	23.2	Srinagar	—	30.0	10.9
Kochi	—	31.6	23.2	Thiruvananthapuram	4.4	31.4	24.8
Kohima	1.6	30.4	22.5	Tiruchirappalli	—	35.5	26.0
Kolkata	2.0	35.2	25.5	Vijayawada	—	33.2	26.8
Kozhikode	—	35.6	28.1	Visakhapatnam	—	33.4	27.0

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO_2	NO_2	CO	PM2.5	PM10	CODE
Ahmedabad	.81	..77	11	 86	...142	
Bengaluru	.15	..24	.—	 39	...133	
Chennai	...5	..11	33	... 111	95	
Delhi	.25	..51	58	... 189	...233	
Hyderabad	...6	..19	13	... 105	...132	
Kolkata	.13	..20	53	... 153	92	
Lucknow	..—	..10	42	... 123	...103	
Mumbai	...6	..33	47	... 169	...132	
Pune	.10	..63	56	 93	...172	
Visakhapatnam	.13	..48	11	... 102	...142	

Yesterday

In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Talcher, Odisha recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 231 indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Nalbari, Assam recorded a healthy AQI score of 23

Air Quality Code: Poor Moderate Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO_2: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO_2: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM2.5 & PM10: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

Cabinet rank post sought for P.J. Joseph

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

In the wake of the Keralam Cabinet clearing the appointments of Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) leader M.K. Muneer as Chairperson of the Administrative Reforms Commission and All India Forward Bloc leader G. Devarajan as the State's Special Representative in Delhi, both with Cabinet rank, the Kerala Congress (KC) has demanded a similar position for its chairperson P.J. Joseph.

Party executive chairman Mons Joseph said the issue of providing an "honourable accommodation" to Mr. Joseph in the UDF had been settled. "...We have not demanded a specific position and it is up to the government to finalise a suitable post for him," he told *The Hindu*.

Five held in woman's abduction, gang rape

The Hindu Bureau
THRISSUR

Five people, including a woman have been arrested on Thursday night in connection with the alleged abduction and gang rape of a woman from Nilambur, in Thrissur, Keralam, on September 22.

The arrests were made by a special team under the direction of Thrissur City Police Commissioner Nakul R. Deshmukh. One of the accused Thomas Priyadarshan Deva was arrested near Nedumbassery airport, and the others from Tiruppur, Coimbatore and Palani, the police said.

Police said the victim and her male companion had checked into a lodge in Thrissur. The man's wife, Devi, who is among the accused, allegedly objected to the relationship and sought the help of Thomas.

Real estate firm promoter held in ₹927-cr. fraud case

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Directorate of Enforcement (ED), Bengaluru Zonal Office, has arrested S. Vasudevan, CMD and promoter of Ozone Urbana Infra Developers Pvt. Ltd., in connection with a money laundering investigation into alleged fraud of ₹927.22 crore involving homebuyers.

He was arrested on September 30 under Section 19 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002, based on multiple FIRs filed at various police stations in Bengaluru.

Flash rain



Rainy ride: Motorists make their way through a sudden spell of rain in Vijayawada, Andhra Pradesh, on Friday. K.V.S. GIRI

A.P. sacks 70 doctors for absenteeism

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

The Andhra Pradesh government has dismissed 70 government doctors for staying away from work without permission for more than a year.

"Action is under way against 193 more," a statement said on Friday. "The action follows directions from Health Minister Satya Kumar Yadav, who has instructed officials not to show any leniency towards prolonged unauthorised absenteeism and to complete the disciplinary process within three months," it said.

The Minister also directed the officials to fill the vacancies arising from such dismissals under the government's "zero vacancy policy."

The Directorate of Secondary Health dismissed 70 Civil Assistant Surgeons, who had remained absent without authorisation for more than a year. Officials are allowing doctors who come forward to rejoin duty, subject to disciplinary measures such as withholding of increments. So far, 78 doctors rejoined duty through this process.

An assessment covering all Heads of Departments under the Health and Family Welfare Department identified 493 doctors and other employees as being absent from duty.

'Keralam CM intervened in posting bid of prosecutor in Basheer case'

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

A. Saifudeen Haji, director, *Siraj* daily, and vice-president, Kerala Muslim Jamaat, on Friday alleged that Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan and Chief Secretary Bishwanath Sinha had a role in scuttling the decision to appoint a special public prosecutor in the trial over journalist K.M. Basheer's death.

The allegation came a day after the Kerala High Court stayed the trial for a month and called for the relevant files related to a September 17 order rejecting Basheer's wife Jaseela C.'s demand for a special public prosecutor.

Basheer, who headed the *Siraj*'s Thiruvananthapuram news bureau, was killed in 2019 when his two-wheeler was rammed by a car allegedly driven by IAS officer Sriram Venkitaraman. He said the government backed out of appointing A. Santhosh Kumar as special public prosecutor after telling the High Court it had agreed in principle. The court had allowed the government one month's time to complete the formalities.

Mr. Saifudeen said that Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala had backed Ms. Jaseela's demand. However, the government rejected her demand in a September 17 order. The CM and the Chief Secretary had intervened to undermine the original Home department decision to appoint the special public prosecutor, he alleged. He added that the Home Minister had expressed his helplessness.

CSIR lab develops new severity score for sickle cell anaemia

V. Geetanath
HYDERABAD

Doctors may soon have a more reliable way to predict how severely sickle cell anaemia (SCA) will affect Indian patients, thanks to a new India-specific disease severity score developed by scientists at the CSIR-Centre for Cellular and Molecular Biology (CCMB).

The new tool, developed using clinical data from Indian children, could improve treatment decisions and disease management as existing international scoring systems do not accurately reflect the clinical profile of Indian patients with SCA.

SCA is an inherited blood disorder caused by a mutation in the beta globin gene, which produces abnormal haemoglobin causing red blood cells to assume a sickle shape, leading to anaemia, severe pain episodes, organ damage and other complications. India is among the countries with the highest burden of the disease, according to Giriraj R. Chandak, physician-scientist and Sir J. C. Bose Fellow at CSIR-CCMB. He and fellow scientists including Suraj S. Nongmaithem, Amitabh Biswas, Swaroop Iyer, Jandhayala Vyshnavi, Archana Wath and Dipty Jain conducted this study.



The new tool could improve treatment decisions and disease management.

Indian patients are said to have a milder disease profile than many African populations.

The revised model – 'ISSI' (India-specific Severity Score), improved clinical assessments to nearly 83%. A second version, 'ISS2', replaced the laboratory measurements with easily observable clinical indicators to achieve an overall concordance of about 85%. This enables clinicians to decide the management without the need for many laboratory investigations.

Keralam Forest department to get animal ambulances from Vantara rehab centre

K.S. Sudhi
KOCHI

Keralam Forest department is partnering with Vantara, the animal rescue, rehabilitation, and conservation project in Gujarat, supported by the Reliance Foundation, to improve veterinary care and wildlife rehabilitation in the State.

The Jamnagar-based centre will soon provide two modern animal ambulances to Keralam: a large one for transporting big animals, such as elephants, priced around ₹85 lakh, and a mid-sized one worth around ₹45 lakh. The vehicles will be brought to Keralam after completing their registration, sources said.



Huge help: Currently, Keralam does not have proper ambulances to transfer larger animals like elephants. REPRESENTATIVE IMAGE

Currently, Keralam does not have any proper animal ambulances to transfer larger animals like elephants. Makeshift vehicle ambulances, which are made by modifying hired lorries, are used for shifting elephants. The proposed vehicle would help the department in transporting large animals, officials said. Four forest veterinarians of the department will attend a five-day advanced training programme on animal care in Vantara from October 4.

Incidentally, a six-member team from the department led by P. Pugazhendi, Chief Wildlife Warden, Keralam, had visited the facility last month. The delegation had the director of Thrissur Zoological Park and the assistant veterinary officer of Kottoor Elephant Rehabilitation Centre among others as its members. The visit had triggered an intense debate as it coincided with the proposal of Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan to shift the museum at Thiruvananthapuram to a location outside the city limits and close to some forested areas.

"Keralam, which has five elephant rehabilitation centres including the ones at Kottoor, Muthanga and Kodanad, can adopt scientific practices for animal rehabilitation," an official said.

Obstacle race

The Special Intensive Revision exercise is threatening universal adult franchise

On Gandhiji's birth anniversary, many Opposition parties, student groups and other citizens took to the streets in Delhi, Mumbai and elsewhere demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar. Their grievance was that Mr. Kumar has presided over a Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise meant to "clean" the electoral rolls, but in practice has become an exercise in the serial disenfranchisement of lakhs of Indian citizens. The BJP-led Union and State governments reacted predictably, refusing permission for the protest and imposing prohibitory orders. In Delhi, the government shut down the Internet in the Jantar Mantar area, closed 11 Metro stations and detained over 700 protesters. In Mumbai, the police denied permission for the gathering at Shivaji Park, but the protesters turned up anyway. The reason for the anger is plain. Emboldened by a deferential Supreme Court verdict upholding the SIR's constitutional validity, the Election Commission of India (ECI) has taken the flawed method that it first adopted in Bihar, added a new exclusion criterion called "logical discrepancies" that it first implemented in West Bengal, and extended it from State to Union Territory (UT). The enumeration process puts the onus on electors to prove their eligibility, with many deleted first and verified later. Getting back onto the rolls after being struck off the draft is onerous, while dubious mass requests for deletion are easy to file and quick to process. Nearly 13.4 crore electors have been removed from the draft rolls across 30 States and UTs – about 14% of the electorate before the revision. Each phase has deleted more than the last: 8.3% in Bihar, 12.9% across the 12 States and UTs of Phase 2, and 17% in Phase 3.

The ECI has said that deleted electors can return during the claims phase, but only as fresh applicants provided they find that they have been struck off. The ECI's own members objected to the plainly illegal changes to procedure. Form 6 was altered without any amendment to the rules, asking applicants whether they, or their parents or grandparents, appeared on the roll of the last SIR. In West Bengal, 16.1 lakh requests were filed to remove electors whom judicial officers had already cleared. A centralised roll database in New Delhi helped make this possible. The ECI has now asked BLOs to restore deleted voters to the rolls; it is an implicit admission that the process disenfranchised many. The semi-corrective steps do not absolve the two Election Commissioners. As majority in the ECI, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi could have overruled the CEC. The exercise, as it is being carried out now, is an obstacle not only to universal adult franchise but also to electoral democracy itself.

Rescue act

Preventing ecological degradation is the way to protect wildlife

The first tiger to be reintroduced in West Bengal represents a triumph of bureaucracy, not ecology. After the National Tiger Conservation Authority found no tigers in the Buxa, Dampa, and Palamau reserves by 2018, it mooted a programme with the Bengal Forest Department and the Wildlife Institute of India that has culminated with a royal Bengal tigress caught in Bihar to be released in Buxa. She is the first of seven to be relocated over two years. Buxa is dotted with settlements and surrounded by revenue villages and tea estates. The region already hosts an elephant population routinely threatened by a railway line, with the railways also planning to restore a route to Jainti. Commercial traffic on the Bhutan-West Bengal road through Buxa is another problem. Estates are also notorious for fragmenting the landscape, including migration corridors. The area's forests have turned into dense woodland with a closed canopy, stifling the growth of grasses and causing herbivore populations to dwindle. The density of chitals, tigers' prey, is dismal; goats, macaques and cattle have become more common in tiger diets in place of their preferred ungulates. Since 2018, the collaboration has reintroduced chitals; artificially opened some canopies to help revive grasslands; and relocated villagers from the reserve's core to mitigate human-wildlife conflicts. This last measure is, however, also a window into the cynical character of the reintroduction programme.

From 1973, India followed preventive conservation practices that protected source populations and their habitats, and maintained prey bases and corridors. Buxa, however, belongs to a more recent, more reactive tradition that also includes Sariska and Panna, where authorities intervened only after tiger populations crashed. A reintroduction programme showcases technical capabilities but is also more expensive and heavy-handed, and reflects Project Tiger's problematic belief that the core habitat needs to be inviolate – one the state machinery has used to override the rights of Adivasis and forest-dwelling communities and disrupt incomes from ecotourism. The reserve is also part of an international wildlife corridor contiguous with Phibsoo in Bhutan, to the north, and Manas in Assam to the east. If these forests offer higher prey density or fewer disturbances, the tigers may disperse. Success at Buxa means introduced tigers establish territories and produce cubs, which survive and breed, with natural immigration maintaining genetic diversity. But success should also be an advance, rather than a rescue, and entails monitoring ecological deterioration such that the state does not wait for tigers to vanish to act and involving communities in and around Buxa in decisions about preventing conflicts and protecting livelihoods.

A Court divided by its own architecture



Suhrith Parthasarathy

Advocate practising in the Madras High Court

On September 23, a two-judge Bench of the Supreme Court of India, comprising Justices Dipankar Datta and Satish Chandra Sharma, delivered a split verdict on a set of petitions which assailed the validity of the Chief Election Commissioner and other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023. Remarkably, the judges were divided not on the merits of the challenge, but on whether a Bench of two was competent to decide the matter at all.

An appointment framework

The statute, which was enacted in December 2023, provides that the Chief Election Commissioner and the Election Commissioners shall be appointed on the recommendation of a selection committee comprising the Prime Minister, the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, and a Union Cabinet Minister nominated by the Prime Minister. This law replaced an interim arrangement that a Constitution Bench of five judges had put in place in *Anoop Baranwal vs Union of India* (2023). Under that arrangement, the Chief Justice of India (CJI) sat as the third member in place of a Minister.

Midway through the hearings in the matter, which began in May, the Union government changed tack and argued that the case raised a substantial question of law as to the interpretation of the Constitution. It therefore claimed that the challenge, in terms of Article 145(3), ought to be heard by a Bench of at least five judges. Curiously, this plea was made even though it found no place in the Union's counter-affidavit.

While Justice Datta rejected the request, Justice Sharma accepted it. Ordinarily, a difference of opinion on a Bench of two is resolved by a Bench of three. But reasoning that a ruling on which of their opinions was correct would only delay matters further, both judges jointly placed the papers before the CJI asking him to consider constituting a Constitution Bench. The upshot is this: the petitioners, who came to court in early 2024, must now wait again.

As Justice Datta rightly held, Article 145(3) merely prescribes that a case involving a substantial question of constitutional interpretation ought to be decided by a Bench comprising a minimum of five judges. It does not ask whether a case is important or whether a statute under challenge is new. As far back as in 1959, in *State of Jammu and Kashmir vs Thakur Ganga Singh*, the Court explained, albeit in a different context, what a question of constitutional interpretation entails. "The question of interpretation can arise only if two or more possible constructions are sought to be placed on a provision – one party suggesting one construction and the other a different one," the Court had held. "But where the parties agree on the true interpretation of a provision or do not raise any question in respect thereof, it is not possible to hold that the case involves any question of law as to the interpretation of the Constitution." A Bench of three judges later applied the same reasoning to Article 145(3) itself, in *People's Union for Civil Liberties vs Union of India* (2003).

The Court needs structural reform to strengthen constitutional adjudication and consistency

A deeper institutional fault

What, then, did *Anoop Baranwal* settle? Justices Datta and Sharma agreed that the committee the judgment had created was a stopgap, meant to last only until Parliament enacted a law. To that extent, the Union may well be right in claiming that the CJI's place on the committee is by no means constitutionally entrenched. But the Constitution Bench also read Article 324 to require that appointments to the Election Commission be insulated from exclusive executive control. This was a clear declaration of law, binding on every court under Article 141. As Justice Datta held, whether a committee in which the executive holds two votes out of three meets that standard is merely a question of applying this settled rule to a new statute.

Justice Sharma's opinion adopted a different test. He held that since "there is no authoritative decision of this Court till date pronouncing upon the constitutional validity of the [2023] Act, the matter must be heard by a Constitution Bench of not less than five Judges." But almost any challenge to a fresh statute would, in this sense, be the first of its kind. On such logic, Benches of two judges could not have decided *Shreya Singhal vs Union of India* (2015), which struck down Section 66A of the Information Technology Act or *NALSA vs Union of India* (2014), which affirmed the right of transgender persons to their self-identified gender. Each called for a searching analysis of the Constitution and its guarantees.

Ultimately, though, a disagreement of this kind points to a deeper fault in the Court's architecture.

When the Court first sat, in January 1950, it had six judges (a sanctioned strength of eight judges). Article 145(3), with its minimum of five, assumed that the Court would, in the main, sit together to interpret the Constitution. Today the Court has a sanctioned strength of 38 judges. It functions largely in panels of two and spends most of its time on special leave petitions. A Constitution Bench is assembled only when the CJI can spare at least five judges from this daily churn. The result, as the scholar Nick Robinson has argued, is not one court but many, with each Bench speaking in its own voice.

To be fair, the joint order signed by Justices Datta and Sharma recognises as much. *Anoop Baranwal* arose out of a petition instituted in 2015, was referred to a Constitution Bench in 2018, and was decided in 2023. The reference in *State of Uttar Pradesh vs Jai Bir Singh*, to decide what counts as an "industry", lay dormant for 15 years from 2002, and took nine more to reach the nine-judge Bench that finally decided it. The judges themselves describe such delay as a source of "institutional embarrassment."

The need for clearer rules

Delay of this kind carries with it a corrosive consequence: it presents the Court with a *fait accompli*. Take the present challenge. By the time it is decided, Commissioners appointed under the law would have overseen multiple State elections and likely multiple general elections too. In their joint order, the judges ask the CJI to explore a permanent Constitution Bench to decide pure questions of constitutional law. The idea is far from new. The Law Commission, in its 229th report in 2009, proposed a Constitution Bench sitting in Delhi, with Benches in different regions of the country hearing ordinary appeals.

A Bench of that form would need no constitutional amendment. The CJI, as the Master of the Roster, can create one tomorrow. But therein lies another difficulty. On a court of 38 judges, the power to decide who sits on which Bench is more than an administrative power. It can, and often does, shape outcomes. We might therefore ask ourselves whether such authority ought to be concentrated in a single office. For a permanent Bench to command confidence, it must be composed through a procedure that is transparent, settled in advance, and based on bright-line rules.

There is, however, a further difficulty. India's legal system is built on a supposed commitment to the principle of *stare decisis*, a promise to stand by things previously decided. Yet, there is little to suggest that the Court's Benches, whatever their size, will consistently honour what earlier Benches have held. The present case shows as much. A Bench of two, albeit divided, has declined to apply a principle settled by a Bench of five, and has sent the case to a Constitution Bench simply because the statute under challenge is new.

The Court, in its original conception, was seen as a guardian of the Constitution that would also hear appeals. Over time, though, it has become a forum that sits predominantly as a court of appeal rather than as a constitutional court. This inversion demands urgent correction. Otherwise, the gravest questions facing the republic will continue to be answered only once the answers have ceased to matter.

India's Model BIT — a decade later, amid changes



Jyoti Singh

Advocate based in Delhi and has been a legal consultant to the Department of Economic Affairs, Government of India

India's effort to revise its Model Bilateral Investment Treaty (BIT) comes nearly a decade after the revised model was approved in 2015. The Union Budget 2025-26 had announced that the model would be revamped and made more investor-friendly. The review comes as both India's treaty practice and the international investment regime are changing. The question, therefore, is not simply whether India should offer investors more or less protection. It is about what India has learnt from the past decade and how those lessons should shape its new model.

A cautious framework

India's 2015 Model BIT emerged from a particular historical context. The *White Industries Australia Limited vs Republic of India* award (2011) and broader concerns over investor-state arbitration contributed to a cautious approach. The model adopted a narrower definition of investment, carefully framed substantive protections, regulatory exceptions and a requirement to exhaust all judicial and administrative remedies for at least five years before commencing treaty arbitration.

India's position has since evolved. It has concluded new-generation investment agreements with the United Arab Emirates (UAE), Uzbekistan and Israel. The India-UAE BIT provides for a three-year period for pursuing local remedies rather than the five-year period under the 2015 Model. The India-Israel Bilateral Investment Agreement (BIA), which entered into force in July 2026, similarly provides for a three-year period for pursuing local remedies. These agreements indicate greater flexibility in India's treaty practice since 2015.

A Model BIT is generally not a rigid template but a starting point for negotiations. It signals to potential treaty partners the protections and obligations a state seeks, while allowing individual treaties to reflect the circumstances and priorities of the parties.

The new model should therefore provide a clear framework for India's future treaty negotiations, while leaving sufficient room for necessary adjustments in individual agreements. It is here that the contributions of Makane Moïse Mbengue are relevant. His scholarship teaches that a developing state need not always be a rule-taker under international investment law, but can also be a rule-shaper through its treaty practice. India's revamp of its Model BIT offers a similar opportunity.

India must draw lessons from a decade of investment treaty experience

The international context has also changed. The United Nations Trade and Development (UNCTAD) points to a shift toward investment facilitation, cooperation, sustainable development and more carefully defined investor protections, with less reliance on traditional investor-state dispute settlement (ISDS). The United Nations Commission on International Trade Law (UNCITRAL) is examining reforms to the ISDS, including a permanent tribunal and appellate mechanism, damages and compensation, and dispute prevention. India's revised Model BIT must therefore respond to a changing investment regime, not merely revisit the 2015 Model.

What a new model must factor in

The new model must consider whether to include the Most Favoured Nation (MFN) provision. In most investment treaties entered into by India, the MFN provision is absent, reducing the possibility for an investor to claim better protection under other treaties. However, if the new model includes this provision, it should be very clear about its scope. In *Emilio Agustín Maffezini vs Kingdom of Spain*, an MFN clause was used to bypass an 18-month local-court requirement by relying on more favourable dispute-settlement provisions in another treaty. *Plama Consortium Limited vs Republic of Bulgaria* rejected the importation of such provisions in the absence of a clear treaty provision. Recent treaty drafting also provides examples of expressly excluding dispute-settlement procedures from the scope of MFN clauses. The scope of the MFN provision should therefore be defined, particularly in relation to dispute settlement.

Investor obligations are another aspect of recent Indian practice that can help set a foundation for the new model. Under the India-Uzbekistan BIT, a state is expressly permitted to assert a counterclaim against an investor or investment. The new model can take a cue from this practice and lay down investor obligations and the circumstances in which counterclaims can be asserted.

The provision on dispute settlement also calls for reassessment. The five-year requirement to exhaust all judicial and administrative remedies under the 2015 Model could be assessed against the practices adopted by India since then. The three-year period for pursuing local remedies used in the India-UAE and India-Israel investment agreements shows greater flexibility in India's approach. The Model BIT may also provide for more effective consultation and dispute-prevention procedures prior to arbitration, which are being discussed at UNCITRAL Working Group III.

Need for precision, clarity

The substantive protections should be equally precise. Clarity of language concerning expropriation and fair and equitable treatment (FET) could help avoid confusion in interpretation while safeguarding the right of the state to regulate for the public good. Sustainable development and responsible investment must not be left as policy declarations. Where India wishes to impose obligations on investors, those obligations should be expressed in clear legal terms. The changes need not make the new model uniformly more favourable either to investors or to states. The aim should be a model that is clearer, more workable and better suited to India's position today, while allowing room for necessary adjustments in individual treaties.

With the revised model now reportedly finalised and awaiting Cabinet approval, the key question will be whether its final text adequately reflects the lessons of India's treaty experience over the past decade while providing a coherent framework for future negotiations.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Service extensions

We have recently witnessed a trend of granting routine service extensions to senior bureaucrats, particularly State Chief Secretaries, Union Secretaries and other officials, beyond their superannuation, leaving aside officials of parastatal bodies. While governments often cite "administrative exigencies" and the need for continuity, the long-term institutional costs can outweigh the short-term benefits, particularly when no compelling administrative necessity exists. As constitutional heads have pointed out in public forums, extending the tenure of retiring officers can demoralise the administrative system and create an artificial bottleneck at the top, limiting the career progression of capable officers next in line. Keeping a select few officials in key positions for extended periods can also blur the line between professional administration and political alignment. There must be merit-based succession. Alternatively, if experience and continued public service are considered essential, the retirement age could be raised to 62.

Sanjoy Das Sarma,
Kolkata

Making dissent visible

The sparse media coverage of the CJP protests on October 2 raises a larger question about what the media chooses to make visible. The media must recognise that it is dealing with a Gen Z already showing signs of deep disillusionment with institutions and politics. When an important section of this generation takes to the streets, ignoring or underplaying it does not make the issue disappear. It can instead reinforce the perception that both the media and the government are indifferent to their concerns.

R. Narayanan,
Navi Mumbai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Deleted, and left in limbo

Across Bihar and West Bengal, lakhs of voters were deleted from the electoral rolls during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise, leaving them unable to vote in the 2025 and 2026 Assembly elections. Over 47 lakh names were deleted in Bihar and nearly 91 lakh in West Bengal. **Shrabana Chatterjee** and **Senjuti Sengupta** met some of those affected, documenting the uncertainty, paperwork, and repeated attempts to prove their citizenship and eligibility that followed the deletions

Deepak Chauhan

35; Ziradei constituency, Siwan district, Bihar; currently unemployed





Reason for deletion: Absent

Chauhan, who is disabled, says he has no idea why he was deleted from the list. He says he was at home at the time of the the exercise and the booth-level officer (BLO) is also from his village. "The BLO knows that I live here and I am alive, but the BLO still marked me absent," he says. Chauhan hopes that local volunteers and activists will be able to get his name on the list. "I live in a lot of pain because of my disability. I don't know how to get my name back on the list. I had applied for a new [voter ID] card, but did not get it," he says. Chauhan, who has never missed voting in an election, says he was unable to vote in the 2025 Bihar Assembly elections. He last voted in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls.

Sunil Sah

36; Ziradei constituency, Siwan district, Bihar; Border Security Force personnel



Reason for deletion: Already registered

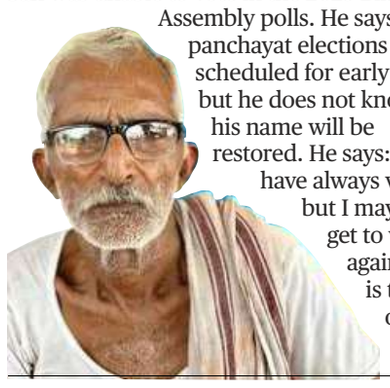
Sah's father says his son was not present during the SIR process to fill up the form. His family filled up the form, yet Sah's name was struck off the list. "He is a government servant. He is serving the nation. And yet his vote has been taken away," says Sah's father. He adds that local activists are helping them fill up Form 6, so that Sah can be registered as a new voter. Sah did not come back from duty to vote in the 2025 elections because his name was deleted, says his father. "Otherwise, he always tries to come back to exercise his democratic right to vote," he says.

Ramashankar Sah

70; Ziradei constituency, Siwan district, Bihar; farmer

Reason for deletion: Already registered

Sah says he has never voted anywhere except in his own constituency. "The cause of deletion is 'already registered'. Why did they remove my name? I don't understand," he says. He also says he had submitted all the documents. He has asked local officials for help, but no one has been able to give him an answer. Local activists are now helping him. Sah was unable to vote in the 2025 Bihar Assembly polls. He says the panchayat elections are scheduled for early 2027, but he does not know if his name will be restored. He says: "I have always voted, but I may not get to vote again. How is that okay?"



Shri Bhagwan Sah

52; Ziradei constituency, Siwan district, Bihar; farmer

Reason for deletion: Already registered

Sah says he has only one voter ID. "This feels like a targeted attack. My whole family was deleted for the same reason," he says. Sah says only local political workers from the Communist Party of India (Marxist-Leninist) Liberation are helping the family by conducting surveys to find out whose names were wrongly deleted. He hopes that they will be able to help him get back on the list. Sah also says he has never missed voting in any election. "But now I fear that I may not get to vote again. This is 'vote chori'. The most marginalised people – SCs, STs, and OBCs – have been impacted by this," he says.

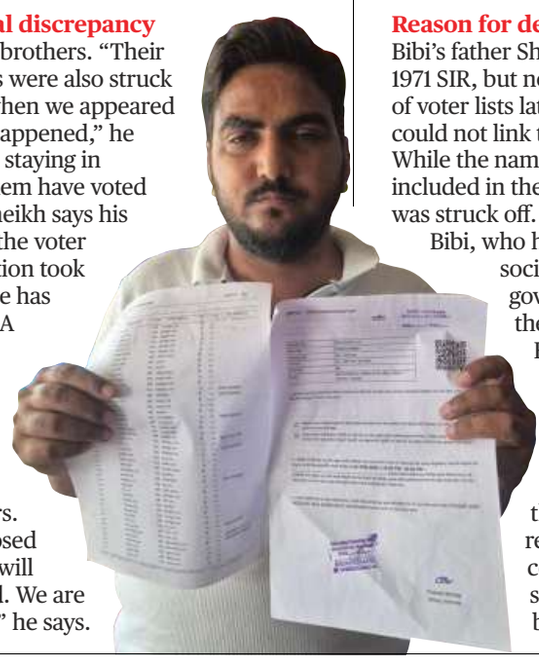


Md. Alauddin Sheikh

47; Samserganj constituency, Murshidabad district, West Bengal; local politician who also contested in 2021

Reason for deletion: Logical discrepancy

Sheikh says he is one of three brothers. "Their names and their wives' names were also struck off. We told the officers that when we appeared for the hearing. But nothing happened," he says. Sheikh's family has been staying in Samserganj for years. All of them have voted regularly over the decades. Sheikh says his great grandfather featured in the voter list of 1952 when the first election took place in independent India. He has appealed before the tribunal. A member of the Social Democratic Party of India in Murshidabad, he believes that the deletion is politically motivated. "The ruling government is excluding all the Muslim voters. Their intention has been exposed through this exercise. But we will resist them. We are not scared. We are all are Indian no matter what," he says.



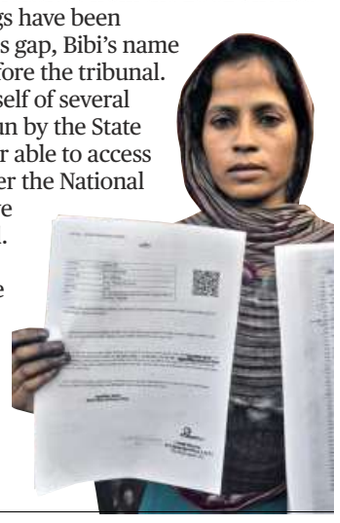
Hazera Bibi

33; Rejinagar constituency, Murshidabad district, West Bengal; bidi worker

Reason for deletion: Unmapped

Bibi's father Sheikh Haider Ali's name was listed both in the 1995 and 1971 SIR, but not in the 2002 SIR. His name was included in revisions of voter lists later as a new voter. Therefore, Bibi and her siblings could not link their names with any relatives from the 2002 SIR list. While the names of her three siblings have been included in the latest SIR despite this gap, Bibi's name was struck off. She has appealed before the tribunal.

Bibi, who had been availing herself of several social welfare schemes run by the State government, is no longer able to access them. Her benefits under the National Food Security Act have also been suspended. "I've been voting since 2019. Now the government seems to believe that I am not even a resident of this country and has snatched away my benefits," she says.



Durgabati Devi

47; Ziradei constituency, Siwan district, Bihar; homemaker



Reason for deletion: Already registered

Devi says she had filled up all the forms that the BLO had provided. "I submitted the documents, I did everything that was asked of me. Yet they deleted my name without any reason," she says. Devi has asked the local officials why her name was deleted and what she should do to get it restored, but again, no one has answers. She is unsure of whether she will ever be able to get back on the electoral rolls. Since her name is absent, Devi says she could not vote in 2025. "For a poor person like me, exercising my franchise is the only power I have in this country. That power has been taken away from me," she says.

Rakesh Chauhan

36; Ziradei constituency, Siwan district, Bihar; labourer

Reason for deletion: Already registered

Chauhan says he had two voter cards because officials filled in the wrong details. This, he says, is what has led to him being included under the 'already registered' category. Now both the cards are invalid. "I have no idea how to get my name back on the rolls," he says. "I have spoken to local gram panchayat leaders and officials. But I could not vote in 2025. I have two voter cards and not a single vote." It is because of the officials' mistake and not his that his voter rights have been taken away, he insists. "How is that okay when the fault was not even mine? This is such a mess," he says.



Faruk Kazi

19; Rejinagar constituency, Murshidabad district, West Bengal; labourer

Reason for deletion: Logical discrepancy

Kazi's parents' names were not listed in the 2002 SIR as they had registered themselves as voters much later. During the survey, Kazi linked his name with his grandfather Hossain Ali whose name was on the 2002 list. All his family members found themselves back in the final voter list in the 2026 SIR, except Kazi. He has appealed before the tribunal. "I was excited to vote for the first time. My parents' names and elder brother's names were included in the SIR. I have no idea why my name was struck off," says Kazi, who registered himself as a new voter only in 2025 and was supposed to cast his first vote in the 2026 Assembly elections. As no decision has been taken yet by the judicial officer in the tribunal, he will also not be able to vote in the upcoming by-poll on October 6.

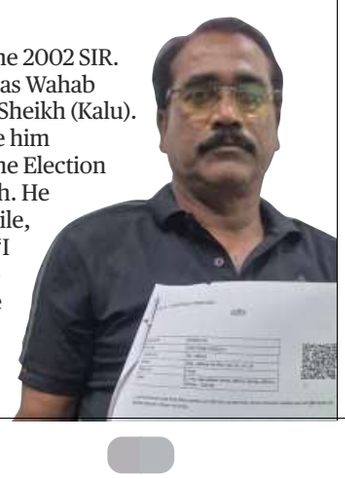


Imamuddin Sheikh

53; Rejinagar constituency, Murshidabad district, West Bengal; elected member of Rampara (II) Panchayat in Rejinagar

Reason for deletion: Logical discrepancy

Sheikh's father Wahab Sheikh's name was listed as Kalu Sheikh in the 2002 SIR. However, his other documents, including the EPIC card, show him as Wahab Sheikh. "Kalu is my father's nickname. He often writes it as Wahab Sheikh (Kalu). But the previous SIR list only registered him as Kalu Sheikh. Despite him providing his EPIC card number, which is the same in the SIR list, the Election Commission did not approve it and removed my name," says Sheikh. He has appealed before the tribunal to get his name restored. Meanwhile, he worries that he will no longer get various government benefits. "I contested in the 2023 panchayat election and won the Rampara (II) seat. But I will not be able to contest in the next election if my name is not restored. My father passed away. But the rest of my family members got their names included in the SIR," says Sheikh who has voted in several elections since 2005.



Md. Mojahar Hossain

39; Samserganj constituency, Murshidabad district, West Bengal; school teacher who also served as a BLO during the SIR

Reason for deletion: Logical discrepancy

Six other people claimed Hossain's father as their own in the 2002 SIR list. Hossain says he doesn't have six siblings. "I have one sister and three brothers. The reason (for deletion) is terribly funny," he says. While the names of his three brothers were included in the latest SIR, his sister's and father's names were also excluded. The Election Commission told his father, Liakat Hossain, that his name did not match the 2002 SIR list. Later, they found that his surname was misspelled as Liakat 'Hosen' in that list although the EPIC number was the same. Hossain has appealed before the tribunal. Three other teachers from his school, who served as BLOs like him, have also been excluded in the SIR this time. "I have surveyed over 1,000 voters in my booth. I had filled up my form with my own hand. Who would have thought that I would be one of those 300 people whose names would be excluded. I don't know what is going to happen next," he says.

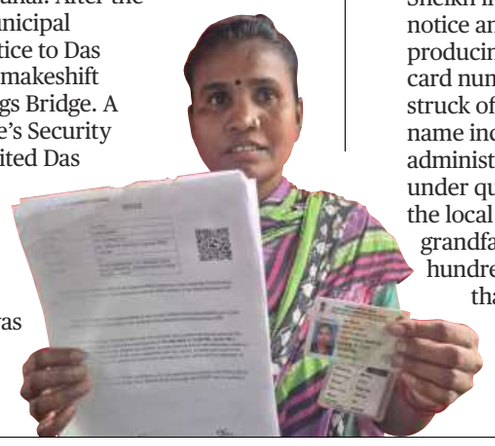


Rati Das

35; Kolkata, West Bengal; Kolkata Port constituency; ragpicker

Reason for deletion: Unmapped

Das is a first-generation voter in her family. Her father died when she was a child. After his death, her mother was driven out by her in-laws. Along with her two children, she occupied a pavement under Hastings Bridge in Khidirpur. Das does not have a permanent house. In 2012, she and her sister got themselves registered as voters and also started exercising their franchise in every election. But now both their names have been struck off as they failed to link themselves with any of their relatives on the 2002 list. Das has appealed before the tribunal. After the deletion, the Kolkata Municipal Corporation issued a notice to Das asking her to vacate her makeshift settlement under Hastings Bridge. A team from Kolkata Police's Security Control Organisation visited Das and her sister last month and checked all their documents. "They asked me whether I came from Bangladesh. How will I prove that I was born and brought up in this city? Could you tell them that I am Indian?"



S.K. Riaz

24; Medinipur constituency, Paschim Medinipur district, West Bengal; student

Reason for deletion: Logical discrepancy

Riaz says there was a discrepancy in his father's name and that, because he had provided his father's name to establish his link to the 2002 rolls during the mapping and form-filling process, his own name was also struck off. He says their cases were sent to the tribunal and are still under adjudication. "We have not heard back from officials on getting our names restored," he says. Since every family member's name was struck off the list, he says the family is not getting their rations. "We have gone to the officials at least six times and filled up multiple forms. Now we get some basic rations, but not the actual quantity we are entitled to. This feels like a targeted attack," he says.



Md Shamim Akhtar

49; Entally constituency, Kolkata, West Bengal; Wing Commander (Retd), Indian Air Force



Reason for deletion: Unknown

Akhtar says he was not placed under any category. He says his name and his father's name were both there in the 2002 voter list. He submitted all the documents, yet in February this year, his name came under adjudication, he says. "When the supplementary lists came out in March 2026, I saw that my name had been deleted. They did not even let me appear for a hearing or give me notice about how to solve the problem. I was struck off without any procedure," he says. Akhtar worries that the BLO has stopped taking his calls. Neither he nor the BLO has any idea how to get his name restored, he says. "This is a complete violation of a person's democratic right," Akhtar adds. "Every person responsible for this should be tried for stripping us of our basic democratic right as a citizen of this country."

Najmatara Khatoon

29; Samserganj constituency, Murshidabad district, West Bengal; Anganwadi worker

Reason for deletion: Logical discrepancy

The name of Khatoon's father, Abdul Haq, was listed as Abdul Haq Sheikh in the 2002 SIR. Due to the mismatch, she was issued a notice and asked to appear for a hearing. Despite producing all the documents, including her father's EPIC card number that matched the 2002 list, her name was struck off. She appealed before the tribunal to have her name included. "When I approached the local district administration officers, they said my nationality is under question," she says. "I have been serving in the local Anganwadi for years. My great grandfather built our home over a hundred years ago. How dare they say that I am not Indian?"



Photo credits: Shrabana Chatterjee and Senjuti Sengupta. Emails: shrabana.chatterjee@thehindu.co.in; senjuti.sengupta@thehindu.co.in

From Page One

Youth and leaders detained amid protests

Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal said members of the Opposition parties are ready to go to jail to save democracy.

The Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI) national president and CPI(M) MP A. A. Rahim, who was detained at Jantar Mantar, said the authorities denied permission for peaceful protests even at the designated protest site. "They have blocked Jantar Mantar, closed down the Metro stations and shut down the Internet....Senior leaders like Brinda Karat and M.A. Baby were detained. But they cannot stop our protests. We will continue our resistance till Mr. Kumar tenders his resignation," Mr. Rahim said.

The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) said the crackdown has raised a fundamental question about the right of citizens to protest peacefully over concerns about their votes. Senior AAP leader Manish Sisodia said in a post on *X*, "The protest is against Gyanesh Kumar, and Amit Shah is engaged in crushing this protest. Today, the Delhi Police is determined to suppress every voice demanding Gyanesh Kumar's resignation."

New Delhi turned into a fortress owing to heavy police deployment and barricading at Jantar Mantar, restricting the entry of people trying to protest. The Students' Federation of India and DYFI had issued a call for the protest to begin from Mandi House. The National Students' Union of India began its march from Raisina Road and members of the Indian Youth Congress joined them.

Prohibitory orders were enforced under Section 163 BNSS in Parliament Street sub-division where the protest site is located, restricting any public meeting. Hundreds of Delhi Police, CAPF and RAF personnel blocked the two entry points of the Jantar Mantar protest site. The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation announced that entry and exit were closed at 12 stations, including those in the immediate vicinity of the protest site. Internet services were shut down at the protest site with shopkeepers facing difficulties in taking UPI payments.

Across India

In Keralam, district units of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) organised rallies demanding the resignation of Mr. Kumar.

In Srinagar, scores of Congress leaders and workers assembled at the party headquarters on M. A. Road. They tried to march towards the main road, but were stopped by police, who did not allow them to step outside the party office complex. In Jaipur, the AAP held a protest at Shaheed Smarak demanding Mr. Kumar's resignation.

Trade deal with India is not 'imminent', says U.S.

The India-U.S. trade deal has been heavily delayed ever since it was announced by Mr. Modi and Mr. Trump in February 2025 due to various tariff actions taken by the U.S.

The larger Bilateral Trade Agreement (BTA) was supposed to have been concluded by "Fall 2025" (October-November 2025). Talks on a "mini deal" addressing only tariffs also failed to fructify.

In February, the two leaders once again issued a joint statement committing to finalising an interim agreement on trade, and continuing negotiating the BTA. The interim agreement was to have been finalised by March-April 2026. Neither the interim deal nor the BTA has so far been finalised.

Mr. Goyal has been vocal in saying that India will not sign a deal until it is made clear that it will receive a comparative advantage over its competitors, as was agreed to in February 2026.

The U.S., on the other hand, has already levied an additional tariff of 10% on India for not doing enough to prevent the import of goods made using forced labour. It is in the process of finalising further tariffs relating to excess capacity.

Centre yet to extend SoO pact with Kuki-Zo groups

Suspension of Operations pact to be kept in abeyance till Kuki-Zo groups surrender all weapons, say officials; Meitei, Naga groups have sought its abrogation; Shah set to visit Manipur next week

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI



Weapons seizure: Arms and ammunition recovered during a security forces operation in Imphal in June 2025. ANI

Amid continuing violence between the Naga and Kuki groups in Manipur, the Union Home Ministry is yet to extend the Suspension of Operations (SoO) pact with the Kuki-Zo insurgent groups, a month after the one-year agreement expired.

On September 4, 2025, the Home Ministry, the Manipur government, and the Kuki-Zo groups had signed the SoO pact on "re-negotiated terms and conditions or ground rules," after the Manipur government in February 2024 refused to extend the agreement, in force since 2008, in the wake of the violence that erupted between the Meitei and Kuki-Zo people on May 3, 2023.

Pact in abeyance

Government sources told *The Hindu* that the pact is in abeyance till all weapons are surrendered by the Kuki-Zo groups. The presence of a large number of weapons with civilians is one of the prime drivers of violence and killings in the northeastern State, a government official said. Meitei and Naga civil society groups, including Deputy Chief Minister Losii Dikho, have demanded the abrogation of the SoO pact.

Due to Naga-Kuki ethnic tensions, more than 40 people have been killed in Ukhrul, Kangpokpi, and Kamjong districts since February 7, three days after President's Rule was revoked in the State.

A member of the Kuki-Zo SoO group said the one-year agreement expired on September 4, but they were yet to hear anything from the Ministry or Ajit Lal, Ministry's Adviser, Northeast, and the interlocutor for peace talks. "The last meeting the SoO groups had with the interlocutor was on April 30. He had said that he will meet us every quarter. There has been so much violence in the State since February and he has not visited the affected areas even once," the SoO member said.

The member claimed that security forces conduct regular inspections of SoO camps and all weapons are accounted for. "Not extending the SoO pact does not mean it has been abrogated," the SoO member said.

During Union Home Secretary Govind Mohan's review of the security situation in the State on September 30, a senior government official said that it was decided to send 30 more companies of the CRPF (around 3,000 personnel) and two battalions of CoBRA (around 2,000 personnel) for deployment in the State.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah is expected to visit Senapati, a Naga-dominated district in Manipur, on October 7. This will be his second visit to the State since the 2023 violence. He had visited Imphal in 2024 to address a rally ahead of the Lok Sabha elections.

History of the pact

The tripartite pact was signed in 2008 by the United Peoples' Front and the Kuki National Organisation, – a coalition of 24 insurgent groups – the Home Ministry, and the Manipur government following the Kuki-Naga clashes in the 1990s that killed hundreds. The insurgent groups demanded an independent land for the Kuki-Zo people. The pact has been extended periodically since 2008. After clashes erupted in 2023, there were strong demands from the valley areas to abrogate the SoO agreement.

Kin of 49 missing people in Manipur to get ₹10 lakh each

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The ethnic conflict in the State claimed 306 lives and displaced more than 60,000 people

The Manipur Cabinet has approved a one-time financial assistance of ₹10 lakh each for the kin of the 49 people missing since the ethnic conflict erupted in the State on May 3, 2023.

Manipur's Home Minister Konthoujam Govindas told the 60-member House in September that the conflicts – first between the Kuki-Zo and Meitei communities and then between the Kukis and Nagas – claimed 306 lives and displaced more than 60,000 people.

"The Cabinet approved a Home Department proposal for the one-time assistance of ₹10 lakh each for the survivors of the 49 missing persons as a special humanitarian measure," Manipur Government spokesperson and MLA Sapam Ranjan Singh told journalists on October 1, after the end of the Cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Yunman Khemchand Singh. The spokesperson said the 49 people remain missing despite search efforts.

"The decision takes into account the difficulties faced by families of missing persons, particularly because existing legal and procedural requirements make it difficult for them to access compensation available to families of those officially declared dead," he said. The law says a missing person is presumed dead only after seven years. Families of such people do not possess death certificates and autopsy reports required under the applicable Central assistance scheme.

"The families of the missing people have been going through hardships similar to those faced by the kin of people killed during the conflict. This was the reason why the government considered their case for the one-time assistance," the spokesperson said.

Among other decisions, the Cabinet also approved an increase in ex-gratia assistance for Army and Central Armed Police Forces personnel killed or injured due to extremist violence while operating in Manipur.

Plea in Supreme Court dubs six-stanza *Vande Mataram* as a 'divisive religious war song'

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI



A tableau by the Ministry of Culture showing the verses of *Vande Mataram* during the Republic Day Parade on January 26, 2026. ANI

A petition in the Supreme Court has termed the six-stanza *Vande Mataram* a "divisive religious war song", and said that government orders imposing a "sectarian prayer to particular goddesses of one particular religion as the National Song" violates fundamental rights of religion; attracts criminal law; and, basically, converts the Indian polity from a "secular republic" to a "theocracy".

The plea filed by B.D. Borkar, a Phule-Ambedkarite and a member of the Scheduled Caste Buddhist community of Maharashtra, represented by jurist and advocate Mohan Gopal, said that a State compulsion expressed through two successive government orders on January 28 and July 9 would lead to the "unstated but undeniable consequence of irreversibly deepening communal division and conflict in India by outraging the religious and spiritual feelings of minority religions".

Mr. Borkar argued that the six-stanza version introduced by Bankim Chandra Chatterjee in his novel *Anandamath* would promote enmity and conflict between different communities by advancing the supremacy of a dominant community. The fabric of unity would be mutilated forever, he said.

The plea said that for 79 years the Union and State governments, public institutions and other groups had peacefully played and sung the "non-*Anandamath*" two-stanza *Vande Mataram* authored by Chatterjee in the early 1870s. "This non-theistic song lauds the natural beauty of Mother Earth, describing the nation as a landscape and pays tribute to a non-deified motherland. The song was treated in this period as the National Song even though not officially declared so," the petition said.

Song versus novel

"The novel *Anandamath* was written by Bankim Chandra Chatterjee after he had composed the two-stanza standalone version of *Vande Mataram*. It was first published in 1881. *Anandamath* presents an idea of India entirely different from that found in the two-stanza standalone song... *Anandamath* is a novel in which Hindu ascetics wage a holy religious war against Muslims who are violently killed and destroyed as a people... The centrepiece of *Anandamath* is a six-stanza war song in which the Hindu combatants pray to Goddesses Durga, Saraswati and Lakshmi as well as the country as a goddess for victory over Muslims," the petition said.

The petition sought the court to intervene to quash the two orders, and stop any manner of compelling citizens, particularly schoolchildren, from singing or playing the six-stanza *Vande Mataram*. It said the court could direct that the two-stanza, standalone version of *Vande Mataram* alone be recognised, treated, performed and sung as the National Song.

On September 22, the top court had orally observed that a democratically-elected government cannot compel conscientious objectors to sing or play one or all the stanzas of *Vande Mataram* under the threat of penal action.



Pargat Singh

Pargat Singh appointed president of Punjab Cong.

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Putting an end to months of uncertainty around the position of the Punjab Congress chief, the All India Congress Committee (AICC) on Friday appointed Congress MLA Pargat Singh as the new president of the Punjab Pradesh Congress Committee (PPCC).

Mr. Singh, a former Minister and captain of the Indian men's hockey team, has been given the new responsibility, after Congress leader Amarinder Singh Raja Warring formally submitted his resignation from the post of PPCC chief to former party president Rahul Gandhi.

Mr. Singh's appointment is seen as a move to curb the ongoing power tussle in the Congress's Punjab unit. The turf war, particularly between former Chief Minister Charanjit Singh Channi and Mr. Warring, was on public display for several months. To tackle this internal turmoil, the party's central leadership replaced Bhupesh Baghel with Sachin Pilot as the party in-charge for Punjab last month. Now, replacing Mr. Warring with Mr. Singh is also being seen as an attempt to pacify the discontented leaders ahead of the crucial 2027 Assembly polls.

Party sources said that Mr. Singh's appointment was driven largely by his clean, non-controversial image. By picking him, the party appears to have struck a balancing act, hoping he can bridge the divide between the two rival camps.

2 'intruders' shot dead by BSF along Punjab border

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Two unidentified suspected intruders were shot dead by the Border Security Force (BSF) along the India-Pakistan border in Punjab's Tarn Taran district on Friday.

A senior BSF official told *The Hindu* that the bodies were lying about 50 metres beyond the border fence till a flag meeting with Pakistan Rangers was concluded.

The official said the identities of the intruders were yet to be established. At the flag meeting, the Pakistan Rangers sought the return of the bodies. "...it has been decided to hand over the bodies after the legal formalities are completed," said the official.

Buxa Reserve regains its stripes with the release of three-year-old tigress

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA



New home: The tigress was brought from Valmiki Tiger Reserve, marking the beginning of a phased programme. X/BYADAVBJP

A three-year-old tigress, T138, was released into the Buxa Tiger Reserve in West Bengal on Friday, marking the beginning of a phased programme to reintroduce tigers and establish a viable, self-sustaining population in the reserve.

The tigress was translocated from Bihar's Valmiki Tiger Reserve and released in the presence of Union Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav and West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari. Mr. Adhikari said three more tigers would be released in Buxa in the next two months. "Inspired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi's push for landscape conservation and species protection, today we have fulfilled the significant promise to reintroduce a tiger in Buxa," Mr. Yadav posted on social media.

Sustained effort

Buxa was declared a Tiger Reserve in 1983. "Over the decades, however, habitat degradation and fragmentation, changes in land use and decline in prey availability have affected the ecological conditions required to sustain a resident tiger population. The Reserve subsequently witnessed a prolonged absence of a stable resident tiger population," a press statement by the PIB said.

The recovery of Buxa has been a sustained, science-based effort and the Tiger Augmentation and Recovery Project, initiated by the Government of West Bengal with support from the National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA) and the Wildlife Institute of India (WII), has been implemented collaboratively since 2018.

Senior forest officials said T138 would be subject to intensive post-release monitoring using a combination of telemetry, camera trapping and field-based monitoring to assess her adaptation, health and behaviour. "The programme is not merely about bringing tigers back to Buxa. Its objective is to create the conditions in which a tiger population can establish, breed and ultimately become viable and self-sustaining," the Union Environment Ministry said.

Congress appoints Aradhana Misra chief of its U.P. unit

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW



Aradhana Misra Mona

The Congress on Friday appointed Aradhana Misra Mona president of the Uttar Pradesh Congress Committee. Imran Masood, Lok Sabha member from Saharanpur, was appointed working president, while Devinder Nishad and Alok Prasad have been appointed senior vice-presidents of the party.

Ms. Mona replaced Ajay Rai, who led the party as the State head for over three years.

Ms. Mona, a three-time MLA from the Rampur Khas Assembly seat under Pratapgarh district, is the daughter of party's senior leader and Deputy Leader in the Rajya Sabha Pramod Tiwari.

The appointment, months before the Assembly polls, is seen as an attempt by the party to forge a social coalition of Brahmin-Muslim-Dalit communities as Ms. Mona and Mr. Masood hail from the Brahmin and Muslim communities, respectively.

Mr. Masood won the Saharanpur seat in 2024 by over 60,000 votes and is considered an influential Muslim leader from western Uttar Pradesh.

If Gyanesh Kumar goes, Modi will have to follow suit: Dipke

Despite lack of permission, over 4,000 people turn up at Mumbai's Shivaji Park seeking CEC's resignation; personalities like Shabana Azmi and Vishal Dadlani take part in protest; this is just a trailer, full picture at Jantar Mantar, says CJP

Snehal Mutha
Yohaan Varghese
MUMBAI



Seeking accountability: Singer Vishal Dadlani, CJP convener Abhijeet Dipke and others at a protest demanding the resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar at Shivaji Park in Mumbai on Friday. EMMANUAL YOGINI

Thousands of protesters demonstrated outside Mumbai's Shivaji Park on Friday against alleged irregularities on electoral rolls and the Election Commission's special intensive revision (SIR), in a protest organised by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on the birth anniversary of Mahatma Gandhi.

Though police permission was not granted for the protest, the demonstrators numbering between 4,000 and 5,000 sat outside the historic Shivaji Park's gates in Dadar with the Tricolour in their hands, seeking the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar. CJP conveners Abhijeet Dipke, Ashutosh Ranka, Saurav Das, and its head of legal affairs, Ratna Singh, addressed the protesters raising slogans such as "Gyanesh, it's done, bro".

The air was filled with slogans of Inquilab Zindabad, *'Ek Jeera, Do Ajwain, Gyanesh karo resign'*, *'Gyanu kaka...rajinama dya, rajinama dya'*, while the beats of patriotic songs such as *Rang De Basanti*, lent colour, sound, and defiance to an otherwise quiet afternoon.

'Freeze SIR process'

The CJP has demanded the resignation of Mr. Kumar and subsequent criminal proceedings against him. It has sought a freeze on the SIR process, restoration of the January 2025 voter list, and repeal of the 2023 law governing the appointment of Election Commissioners.

Addressing the protesters, Mr. Dipke said that if Mr. Kumar was removed from his post, then Prime Minister Narendra Modi "will also have to go".

Mr. Ranka said: "Prime Minister Narendra Modi's shop is running because of the EC. Who the hell is Gyanesh [Kumar] to take away the Babasaheb's Constitution." He added that "this is just a trailer as the picture will be at Jantar Mantar in Delhi".

"We should not be afraid of detention. We should not be afraid of arrest. They will try to scare and threaten us, but we are not going to be afraid," Mr. Ranka told the protesters.

Prominent figures, including actor Shabana Azmi and singer Vishal Dadlani, were present. "Since childhood we have been hearing voting is our right, but if the same right is taken away, then what will we do? We protest...," Ms. Azmi said.

Gangadhar Menon, 70, one of the protesters, said: "So far, we were talking that VVPAT (Voter Verified Paper Audit Trail) had problems, but this has gone way too deep. Now, they are going for voters' list itself."

Comedian Rajiv Nigam, who addressed the gathering, said: "When our right to vote is taken away, all of us will have to raise our voices together."

NCP leader Anish Gawande said the SIR exercise had affected marginalised groups, claiming that "people from Assam who did not have documents because of floods" and "transgender persons without identity cards" had their names removed from the electoral rolls.

Regarding the number of protesters, a senior police official from Dadar present there said: "The inflow of people is reported to be 4,000-5,000 and police force deployed is around 800, along with riot control police units."

Senior citizen dies

A 75-year-old man who had come to witness the protest died of heart attack. He was identified as Gopalakrishna Subbaiya Pillai, of Thane. Around 5 p.m., he complained of chest pain and was taken to a hospital, where he died, Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCP) Mahendra Pandit said.

The Hindu unveils *Gandhi for Gen Z* documentary

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI



N. Ram, Director, The Hindu Group; N. Murali, Chairman; L.V. Navaneeth, CEO; and Suresh Nambath, Editor, *The Hindu,* at the launch of the documentary in Chennai. S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

The Hindu on Friday launched its documentary *Gandhi for Gen Z* on the occasion of Gandhi Jayanti.

Editor Suresh Nambath and CEO L.V. Navaneeth released the documentary in the presence of N. Murali, Chairman, The Hindu Group Publishing Private Ltd., and N. Ram, Director, The Hindu Group Publishing Private Ltd.

The 35-minute documentary looks at the large-scale student protests earlier this year through the lens of Mahatma Gandhi's teachings about ushering in change through disciplined, non-violent protests. It proposes that the philosophies of the Mahatma may be relevant even to a generation that has not studied him beyond mentions in school textbooks.

Opening with scenes of the protests at Jantar Mantar in June and moving between archival footage of Gandhiji's life and work during the freedom struggle, the film delves into how a protest triggered by a leaked examination paper expanded into an expression of young people's anxieties about today's political climate.

Besides, it looks at how the protesting students used the oldest tools in the country's political memory – hunger strikes and disciplined non-violent protests – tools that Gandhiji had created decades earlier.

It examines how the young protesters placed Gandhiji and Dr. B.R. Ambedkar side by side, drawing lessons from both, despite an old, established discourse that pits the two against each other.

Footage of police action against the protesters and their lack of retaliatory violence reinforced the Gandhi connection: *ahimsa,* both as moral principle and as a political strategy.

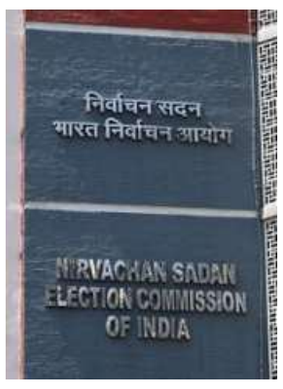
The documentary features interviews with historian and author Ramachandra Guha, former West Bengal Governor and Gandhiji's grandson Gopalkrishna Gandhi, social activist and Gandhiji's great-grandson Tushar Gandhi, Cockroach Janta Party's chief spokesperson Saurav Das, and Self-Employed Women's Association director Mirai Chatterjee.

"The documentary is very relevant and timely because it brings out, in a meaningful and real way, the relevance of India's freedom struggle, which was led by Gandhiji, particularly the method of mass protests and the reasons for not using violence," said Mr. Ram, noting that the connection between the freedom struggle and the student protests is portrayed very authentically in the documentary.

The documentary was spearheaded by Pradeep Gairola, business head – digital, The Hindu Group. It was directed by Shikha Kumari A. and edited by Naveen Kumar V., with camerawork and post-production handled by members of *The Hindu*'s video team. It is available on *The Hindu's* YouTube channel.

EC directs BLOs to enrol voters left out of SIR rolls within a month

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



The Election Commission (EC) has directed the Chief Electoral Officers (CEO) of all States and Union Territories where the special intensive revision (SIR) has been completed or is under way to compare the pre-SIR voter lists with the current ones and enrol, within one month, those who have been left out but are eligible.

In a letter to the CEOs of all States and Union Territories, the EC has said that booth-level officers (BLO) should prepare a list of electors whose names had been left out, and make door-to-door visits to ascertain their present status and ensure their enrolment through Form 6 if the concerned person is found eligible.

"BLOs shall compare the current electoral roll with the pre-SIR electoral roll and identify such electors whose names were there in the pre-SIR roll but who are not included in the current electoral roll and prepare a list of such electors," the letter said.

It further said that BLOs shall undertake house-to-house visits in respect of such identified electors to ascertain their present status and facilitate enrolment through Form 6, wherever the person is found to be eligible.

The EC's letter, which was issued after a video conferencing with all the CEOs, suggested that the BLOs may cover at least 20-25 electors in a week so as to complete this exercise within a period of about one month.

"They shall also indicate the present status of each such elector in the list prepared by them. The electors for whom Form 6 has been filled up will also be indicated."

The BLOs will share this list with the BLAs of recognised political parties and the EROs, along with filled-in Form 6 application forms and their field verification reports.

Booth-level camps

Apart from this, booth-level camps shall be organised to facilitate submission of applications for enrolment. Special camps may also be organised for enrolment of people living in night shelters, labour colonies as well as for homeless and marginalised persons.

Till now, approximately 13.3 crore names have been deleted from the electoral rolls in States where the SIR process has been completed or is under way. An analysis by *The Hindu* found that around 2.7 crore or 21% have been declared dead, and of the remaining, approximately 1.01 crore have been flagged as multiple entry cases and 9.5 crore marked in the absent/shifted/others category. This in effect means that 72% of the voters whose names have been deleted could be back in the voter lists once the SIR process is completed.

The EC has already announced a special drive to enrol new voters.

However, former Chief Election Commissioner S.Y. Quraishi has questioned the EC's move to re-enrol voters using Form 6.

He said Form 6 cannot be filled by a deleted voter. "It's only for NEW voters. All those who have been forced to fill it have committed criminal offence carrying one year prison. EC officials who forced them are abetters to crime. This press note shows ECI's abetment!", he said in a post on X.

Re-enrolment drive will not include Bengal voters under adjudication

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI



People gather to submit their applications to a tribunal set up to hear appeals related to SIR in Alipore, Kolkata. FILE PHOTO

The Election Commission's (EC) special "door-to-door" drive to re-enrol any voter left behind during the SIR process through Form 6 will not be applicable to the more than 20 lakh voters in West Bengal whose cases are pending before the appellate tribunals. This could create two parallel re-enrolment routes, one through the tribunals and one through Form 6 applications to electoral registration officers (EROs). The EC has directed Form 6 applicants to be cleared within a month, while the tribunal appellants could wait several years.

A senior EC official told *The Hindu* that while booth-level Officers (BLOs) would re-check if any voters are left out among the ASDD (absent/shifted/dead/duplicate) list which was issued after the enumeration phase, those whose cases are in the tribunals "is different as it is already under adjudication".

According to an affidavit submitted by the EC in the Supreme Court, 22.21 lakh appeals are pending before the tribunals in West Bengal.

The appellate tribunals came out of Supreme Court's supervision of the SIR. Judicial officers, drawn from a list sent by the Calcutta High Court at the Supreme Court's direction, were adjudicating the roughly 60 lakh "doubtful and pending" cases. On March 10, the apex court directed that a separate appellate body be set up so that people could challenge those officers' decisions. On March 21, the EC constituted 19 Appellate Tribunals for West Bengal.

Before this, during enumeration phase, about 31.7 lakh voters (31,68,424) were identified as "unmapped", meaning they could not be linked to the 2002 electoral roll. A further approximately 1.36 crore were flagged under "logical discrepancy". Both groups were called for hearings after the draft roll was published on December 16 last year.

Around 60 lakh cases were still unresolved when the final roll was published on February 28 after the hearings had cleared the rest.

Unresolved appeals

The West Bengal Congress has said that since the enrolment drive was announced just before the October 6 by-elections in Nandigram and Rejinagar, where over 6,000 and 12,000 appeals, respectively, remain pending, these voters would be deprived of their vote for a second consecutive time. The party unit chief, Shubhankar Sarkar Prasenjit Bose, in a letter to the EC, asked for all 22.21 lakh appellants to the electoral roll to be restored provisionally until their appeals are finally decided, or to convert all pending tribunal appeals into Form 6 applications.

Cong. accuses EC of 'lying' about ECINet, demands accountability

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Friday accused the Election Commission (EC) of "lying" about the legality of its ECINet platform and violating electoral laws, with party general secretary Jairam Ramesh demanding accountability for what he described as "violations of the law and the Constitution".

Mr. Ramesh said the EC, in a September 26 press note, had announced the formation of a committee to certify that ECINet complied with the relevant Acts and Rules. He described the move as "damage control but actually damage enhancing".

"This should never have been in doubt at all in the first place if the intentions of CEC Gyanesh Kumar were honest – which they were not," he said.

ECINet was launched on January 22 with the stated objective of enhancing transparency and public trust. The EC had said at the launch that the platform had been "developed in strict accordance with the law". "All of this was a lie," Mr. Ramesh said.

He alleged that by restricting electoral registration officers' (EROs) access to the ECINet voter-roll system and overruling EROs in Goa, West Bengal and other States, the EC had violated the Representation of the People Act, 1950 and the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960.

"Both these laws establish that the ERO has statutory authority over the electoral roll," he said, citing a September 24 letter from the Maharashtra Chief Electoral Officer seeking correction of the alleged irregularity.

"Starting today, the INDIA janbandhan, citizens and many civil society organisations will hit the streets across the country demanding accountability for these violations," Mr. Ramesh said.

Panel of ex-judges to inquire into SIR aftermath

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A lawyers' group issued a statement on Friday announcing the constitution of an independent panel of former Supreme Court and High Court judges to enquire into growing concerns regarding the design, implementation, and consequences of the special intensive revision (SIR) exercise undertaken by the Election Commission.

The Lawyers Association for Constitution (LAFC) said the panel aims at coming up with a report by December 2026.

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NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Online bids are invited to procure up to 1000 MW power from 01st November 2026 to 30th September 2027 on short term basis from various Generators/ State Utilities/ CPPs/ Distribution Licensees/ SEBs/ Trading Licensees as per specification under TN-35/RUVITL/FY 2026-27. May visit website **www.mstcecommerce.com/ www.energy.rajasthan.gov.in/ruvks/#/home/dptHome** for further details.

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OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, P.W.D. DN. VALLABHNAGAR
No. :- 916 Date :-25.09.2026

Notice Invision Bid No. 08/2026-27
NIB No. :- PWD2627A3001

Bids for Various works are invited from interested bidders from **01.10.2026 9.00 AM to 08.10.2026 Upto 06.00 PM**. Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal ("http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in" and "http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in") of the state, and department website. The approximate value of procurement of **05 Works is Rs. 301.23 Lacs.**
UBN No :-

1	PWD2627WSOB13528
2	PWD2627WSOB13529
3	PWD2627WSOB13530
4	PWD2627WSOB13531
5	PWD2627SLRC13532

(Mahendra Singh Saini)
Executive Engineer
P.W.D. Dn. Vallabhnagar

DIPR/C/16805/2026

APPOINTMENT

GOVERNMENT OF PUDUCHERRY
DIRECTORATE OF HIGHER & TECHNICAL EDUCATION
LAWSPET, PUDUCHERRY

No.1409/DHTE/Estt/E5/PTU-VC/2026 Date:01.10.2026

APPOINTMENT OF VICE-CHANCELLOR OF PUDUCHERRY TECHNOLOGICAL UNIVERSITY

The Search-cum-Selection Committee for the appointment of Vice-Chancellor for Puducherry Technological University, Puducherry invites applications/nominations from "Distinguished academician, with a minimum of ten years of experience as Professor in the field of Engineering and Technology in a University or ten years of experience in reputed research and / or academic administrative organisation with proof of having demonstrated academic leadership".

The Vice-Chancellor shall hold office for a period of five years, or till he attains the age of superannuation as specified by the University Grants Commission from time to time, whichever is earlier, with no provision for re-appointment/extension.

The application form is available in the website **dhte.py.gov.in.** The filled-in application form should be submitted in a sealed envelope clearly marked "Application for the post of Vice-Chancellor" addressed to the Director, Directorate of Higher & Technical Education, Tholkappiyar Street, Lawspet, Puducherry – 605008 and the soft copy in .pdf format should be emailed to **estt@dhtepdy.edu.in.** The Search-cum-Selection Committee reserves the right to consider or not to consider any application and recommend any person(s) of eminence outside the list of such applications.

The filled-in application in the prescribed format should be submitted on or before **5.30 PM of 31.10.2026.**

Sd/-
DIRECTOR
(Higher & Technical Education)

NO.221/DIP/AD(PRESS)/2026-27

INBRIEF



IIT-B students begin hunger strike protesting Sahil's death

A group of IIT-Bombay students protesting against the death of second-year student Sahil Wakode began a hunger strike on Friday, demanding accountability from the institute's administration and the resignation of its Director. The students, who have been protesting for the past 15 days, decided to intensify their agitation after Wakode's parents, who are on a hunger strike at Azad Maidan in Mumbai, were denied permission to continue their protest on weekends. Mr. Wakode was found dead in his hostel room at the IIT on September 18. His family alleged he had faced caste-based discrimination at the institute. *Counselling is available at Tele MANAS 14416.* PTI

HC to hear PIL plea on noise pollution after student's death

The Allahabad High Court has initiated *suo motu* proceedings on noise pollution following reports of the death of a seven-year-old Class 2 student at a school in Balrampur on September 22 while a procession carrying loudspeakers and a music system was passing nearby. According to reports, the procession was part of the 10-day Ganpati Utsav, which started on September 14. Observing that the death raises larger questions over the unchecked menace of noise pollution, a Division Bench of Justice Rajan Roy and Justice Manjive Shukla on Wednesday ordered the registration of a separate *suo motu* PIL plea while hearing an existing case concerning the use of pressure horns, modified silencers, and hooters.

Seven killed in highway accident in Maharashtra

Snehal Mutha
MUMBAI

At least seven people were killed and 18 injured in an accident involving a truck and a pickup van on the Samruddhi Expressway near the Dhamangaon railway station in Amravati district of Maharashtra early on Friday morning.

A senior police official said the accident occurred on a high-speed carriageway near the railway station. The devotees were travelling from Buldhana district to Wardha with an idol of goddess Durga. According to the police, two people are reported to be in critical condition.

The devotees were members of a Durga Puja committee who were taking the idol for installation in Wardha ahead of the Navratri festival.

"As per preliminary information, the truck rammed the pickup van from behind, throwing several commuters onto the road. Five people died on the spot," an Amravati police official said. An investigation is under way. The injured were taken to a hospital. The accident has once again raised concerns over road safety, as the expressway has witnessed several major accidents since its inauguration.

Used every bit of my energy to save lives, Captain Smit tells PM

Modi lauds flydubai pilot, saying that the country could proudly say that Indians were even willing to risk their safety for the welfare of others

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi spoke to flydubai pilot Captain Smit Machchhar over a video call on Friday and lauded him for foiling an attempt to crash an Israel-bound flight. He called the pilot a hero who proved to the world that Indians "are willing to risk their lives to save others".

"Today is Gandhi Jayanti, you have shown the world what the true meaning of '*ahimsa*' (non-violence) is," Mr. Modi told Captain Machchar. The pilot called Mr. Modi his "biggest idol".

Captain Machchhar is currently hospitalised in the UAE, recovering from wounds he received when his co-pilot attacked him in an alleged bid to seize control of the aircraft that was going to Tel Aviv. A wounded Captain Machchhar opened the cockpit door, after which passengers overpowered the co-pilot.

Speaking about his ordeal with Mr. Modi, Captain Machchhar said that during the scuffle with his co-pilot, his 17 years of flying made him realise the grim fate awaiting the passengers if he failed to act. "I was lying on the floor (of the cockpit), injured. I was still getting hit, but realised that the plane was losing altitude. I told myself to give it one last try and open the door... because although I was thinking of saving myself, I could not bear to think of what would happen to others if I didn't act. With whatever energy was left in me, I managed to act and open the door," he said, adding that passengers thereafter saved the day.


Captain Smit Machchhar

"At that time, you received so many injuries and were engaged in a fight for life and death. But you ignored your own safety and were concerned about the safety of the passengers. You have enhanced the honour of 140 crore Indians. I feel proud from the bottom of my heart," Mr. Modi said.

Captain Machchhar said that he always recites the *Hanuman Chalisa* whenever he is in difficulty, as he did that day.

Lauding his bravery, presence of mind, and composure, the Prime Minister said Captain Machchhar took the decision in a fraction of a second and saved the lives of so many people.

"After this incident, the country can proudly say that Indians are not those who take lives, but those who are willing to risk their lives to save others," Prime Minister Modi said. He said that had Captain Machchhar not acted, fingers would have been raised against Indians and Indian pilots and their safety records. "You have truly done a great thing," he said.

Rising food prices affecting kitchen budgets: Congress

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI


Jairam Ramesh

The Congress on Friday accused Prime Minister Narendra Modi of being insensitive to the burden of rising food prices on households, with the party's communication chief, Jairam Ramesh, describing him as the *pravachan mantri* (sermonising Minister).

Mr. Ramesh shared on X a media report which said household kitchen budgets had increased by 20% to 25% over the past three months.

"Inflation isn't just rising in statistics; its pain is being felt in the kitchens of every middle-class and poor household," he said in a post, alleging that the kitchen budget had risen by up to 25% in three months and that too during the festival season.

Citing the experience of a homemaker with a monthly income of ₹35,000, the Congress leader asked, "Does Modi*ji* realise how all these families must be managing their household budgets in this era of inflation?"

Mr. Ramesh cited increases in the prices of several food items, saying *arhar dal* had risen from ₹105 to ₹140-₹150 a kg, *moong* from ₹95 to ₹120, rice from ₹42-₹45 to ₹53-₹55, and mustard oil from ₹165 to ₹190 a litre.

He also cited government data to say food inflation stood at 5.95% in August, while onion, ginger, and garlic prices had risen by 48.27%, 73.82%, and 43.6%, respectively.

"For the government, these may be just numbers, but for the public, it's a household budget unravelling every month," Mr. Ramesh said. "When will the people of the country get relief from this back-breaking inflation? The insensitivity of the *pravachan mantri* knows no bounds."

The government, however, has dismissed the Opposition's claims and pointed to the strength of the economy, including the latest GDP numbers.

Global South must be paid for climate damage, but only if it prices carbon, argues economist

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI



> We're proposing Indians receive money unencumbered. Spend it on whatever you want. That is based on the amount of damage the OECD countries' emissions are doing. The payment would go directly to the people, not to the government
>
> **MICHAEL GREENSTONE**
> Director, Energy Policy Institute, University of Chicago

Rich countries should pay people in developing countries for the climate damage their emissions cause, on condition that those countries put a price on carbon. That is the central proposal of a forthcoming book, *Just Economics*, by University of Chicago economist Michael Greenstone, with Nobel-Prize winning economists Abhijit Banerjee and Esther Duflo.

"We're proposing Indians receive money unencumbered," Mr. Greenstone, who is Director, Energy Policy Institute, University of Chicago, said in an interview. "Spend it on whatever you want. That is based on the amount of damage the OECD countries' emissions are doing." The payment, he said, "would go directly to the people, not to the government."

The Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD), is a grouping of mostly wealthy, industrialised countries that has contributed to most of the accumulated carbon in the atmosphere driving global warming. This contrasts with the "Global South", meaning low- and middle-income countries but whose emissions are fast rising. "Eighty two per cent of the emissions going forward are projected to be outside the OECD and moral appeals have failed," he reckoned, "the better angels-argument ain't working." However the transfer would be "contingent on the Global South adopting carbon pricing. It's not for free. It's a deal. You have to give something to get something." Mr. Greenstone said it was possible to calculate the damage from carbon emissions to India.

"However the exact parameters of that will have to be negotiated. Such a deal did not require the whole world and could be struck between, say, the European Union and India, he argued.

Market-based solution

Much of Mr. Greenstone's work is around designing market-based solutions to address pollution.

Most prominent is the Surat Emissions Trading Scheme for controlling particulate matter, first mooted with the Gujarat Pollution Control Board in 2010. In a randomised trial, 150 textile plants were assigned to a market and 150 stayed under conventional regulation.

Compliance in the market was "99%", against about a third of industries out of compliance at any time under the status quo. This happened because researchers could see what firms bid to buy and sell pollution permits: "The price I want for that has got to be at least what it cost me to do it. From those bids, we were able to infer how expensive it was to achieve different levels of total emissions. Cutting emissions proved cheap, because the guys had all the equipment and just had to start operating it or maintaining it," he explained.

Enforcement mattered. When firms fell short of permits, the regulator levied a fine of ten times the permit value.

"Once the industry saw that the rules were going to be enforced then everything changed," he said.

India standardises names of 28 places in Ladakh

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Centre says formal identification on map is aimed at ensuring accurate recognition and creating greater awareness among the public

The Government of India, in consultation with the Union Territory administration of Ladakh, has identified 28 places and geographical features in the region by standardised names on the official Survey of India (SoI) map.

The government said the formal identification on the map was aimed at ensuring accurate recognition and creating greater awareness among the public. The latest notification comes days after India standardised the names of places in Arunachal Pradesh amid cartographic aggression by China.

The list in Ladakh includes 11 peaks, five mountains, six land areas, two glaciers, two passes, one valley, one river, one lake and one other water body.

Among the peaks identified are Atisha Giri, Kanishka Peak, Martand Giri, Zorawar Peak, Rinchen Zangpo, Sakyasri Giri, Marpa Lotsava Ri, Milarepa Kangri, Shiva Ri, and Maheshvara Ri. The list also includes Karun Pir, Drak Karpo and Jolmori as mountains.

The government has identified Brangsa, Kuksel, Dehra Compass, Gogra, Kumarayana Point, Panglung, and Shamal Lungpa as land areas. Parpik and Skamri Glacier have been classified as glaciers, while Chapchingal Pass and Shachmirk Pass have been identified as passes.

Other features on the list include Shkorga Valley, Yangpa River, Guru Rinpoche, which has been identified as a lake, and Hot Spring, classified as a water body.

The government said the map of Ladakh, incorporating the additional places and geographical features, can be viewed on the Survey of India website.

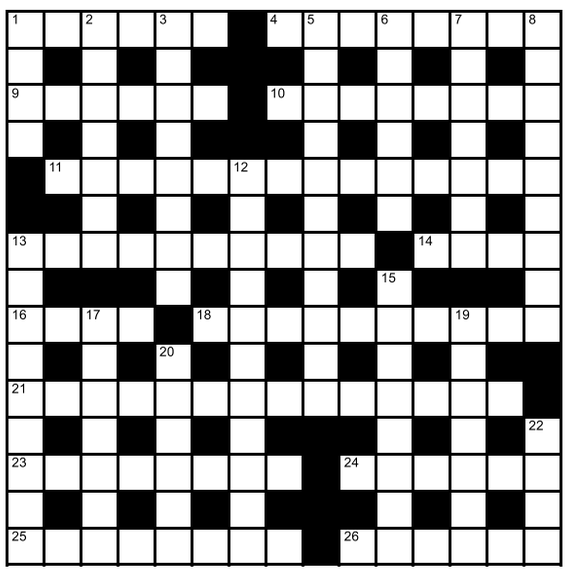
Since April 2020, the Chinese People's Liberation Army (PLA) has amassed a large number of troops and armaments in eastern Ladakh and other areas along the 3,488-km-long LAC. The PLA moved into Indian territory and built fortified structures and defences, in an attempt to permanently alter the *status quo* on the ground.

TH CROSSWORD + 14914

(set by Avtaar)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

1 That is Avtaar entering when I have left, naturally (6)
4 Amateur boxing tour disrupted near Cambodia's capital (8)
9 Abandon plant amidst pandemonium (6)
10 Uplifting energy provided in passing (8)
11 Supply from Canada losing money with onset of recession almost trebled result of international sales (7,2,5)
13 Throughout a meeting emotional quotient essentially found wanting (10)
14 Partners exchanged, means to send data for tweeters? (2-2)
16 Playful bow (4)
18 Part of physics involving inversion of model data (10)
21 Shouting *Help*, say, about introduction of arbitrary rule probing storage fee (8,6)
23 Director left for Illinois, developing office tower? (8)
24 Smelly wonky old studio releasing toxins at the entrance (6)
25 Doctor listened and volunteered (8)
26 Right through, ace is ahead (6)

Down

1 Exposed factor in rising redundancy (4)
2 Mom's vehicle given touch of artificial colouring in front (7)
3 Wife visiting America enters Michigan, say, with Republican congressman (8)
5 Composed a story *Ditch of Still Water*? (11)
6 Foot for base of prop in standing counter (6)
7 One old Communist leader turned up checking doctor's paperwork? (7)
8 Science of drawing? (9)
12 Leader quitting act of voluntary humiliation following judge's sanction (11)
13 Short-tempered herbalist uncovered case of Icelandic nuts (9)
15 Head to investigate mudslinging Brit? (8)
17 Cheerful bird lifted face (7)
19 Smart mature women leaving tribe? (7)
20 Group of stars held at the borders, say, furtively hiding ecstasy (6)
22 Sailor entertains special authority on a subject (4)

SUDOKU

1			6				2	
	3		5	8				
5				2	7			
6	5				8			
		1				8		
			3				9	7
			1	4				6
				5	9		3	
	9				2			8

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

No.SS7020 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

Solution to previous puzzle

D	E	L	I	C	A	T	E	■	B	R	A	H	M	S
E	■	A	■	U	■	R	■	P	■	E	■	O	■	U
A	D	H	A	R	M	A	■	U	P	D	A	T	E	D
R	■	O	■	T	■	P	■	S	■	I	■	S	■	D
T	E	R	M	S	■	D	E	H	Y	D	R	A	T	E
H	■	E	■	E	■	O	■	T	■	■	■	U	■	N
■	■	■	H	Y	P	O	T	H	E	T	I	C	A	L
E	■	G	■	E	■	R	■	E	■	A	■	E	■	Y
S	O	U	N	D	A	S	A	B	E	L	L	■	■	■
C	■	N	■	■	■	P	■	O	■	L	■	B	■	F
A	R	G	E	N	T	I	N	A	■	O	L	I	V	E
R	■	A	■	A	■	D	■	T	■	R	■	H	■	I
G	O	D	L	I	K	E	■	■	O	R	D	E	A	L	S
O	■	I	■	V	■	R	■	U	■	E	■	R	■	T
T	E	N	D	E	R	■	E	T	E	R	N	I	T	Y

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

8	9	1	5	3	7	6	4	2
5	6	2	4	8	1	7	9	3
7	4	3	2	9	6	8	5	1
9	3	6	7	4	5	1	2	8
4	1	5	6	2	8	9	3	7
2	7	8	9	1	3	5	6	4
1	2	4	8	5	9	3	7	6
3	5	7	1	6	2	4	8	9
6	8	9	3	7	4	2	1	5

FAITH

Kindness conquers all

The word *vazhga* appears six times in the opening lines of Saivite preceptor Manikkavachakar's Siva Puranam. What does it signify? It refers to the six enemies within us, said Dr. Sudha Seshayyan.

Maniikkavachakar says the six enemies are *kamam* (desire), *krodham* (anger), *lobham* (greed), *moham* (delusion), *madam* (ego) and *matsaryam* (jealousy). They reside within the five senses and these five should not be merely overcome but won. No one can predict when any of these will surface. Even in bhakti these traits might show and should be mastered. The example of Sundarar's experience at Devasriya mandapam in Tiruvarur is a case in point.

Sundarar, one of the four Saivite preceptors along with Manikkavachakar, had a wonderful relationship with God, due to which he ignored other *adiyars* (servants of God), overlooking the tenet that one should first pay obeisance to the servitors before praying to God at the Devasriya mandapam. Noticing this, Virumandiyar, a servitor stopped Sundarar from proceeding towards the deity. Impelled by his ego, Sundarar refused to acknowledge the servitors and stormed out. Walking agitatedly within the compound, he passionately asked Siva why He did not stop the servitor, thereby denying him a darshan. Suddenly, the preceptor heard a voice calling out to him from above; looking about he espied the deity standing precariously on the temple gopuram. Sundarar conquered his ego and made peace with the servitor. God never leaves the hearts of His devotees, no matter how many deficiencies there may be. Kindness conquers all.

INBRIEF



Amazon Now expands to more than 120 Indian cities

Amazon has expanded its ultra-fast delivery service, Amazon Now, to more than 120 cities across India, doubling its footprint in two weeks as the e-commerce giant steps up its delivery network ahead of the festive season. Amazon Now offers of thousands of products, including groceries, fruits and vegetables, frozen food, personal care items, fashion and beauty products, small appliances and home and kitchen goods. Orders are fulfilled via a network of almost 800 micro-fulfillment and urban fulfillment centres, the firm said. Amazon said in September that Amazon Now had crossed $1 billion in annualised gross sales in India based on the previous three-month period. The company plans to expand the service to more than 300 cities and build what it describes as India's largest "delivery-in-minutes" network. PTI

FPIs turn net sellers, pull out ₹35,860 crore in September

After two consecutive months of buying, foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) turned net sellers in September pulling out ₹35,860 crore from Indian equities amid global uncertainties, elevated U.S. interest rates and high crude oil prices. The selling continued into October, with FPIs pulling out ₹9,232 crore from equities on October 1, as per data from Central Depository Services Ltd. The outflows came after FPIs invested ₹20,200 crore in Indian equities in July and ₹29,630 crore in August. With the latest selling, FPIs have now withdrawn about ₹2.7 lakh crore from Indian equities so far in 2026 vis a vis ₹1.66 lakh crore outflow in entire 2025. Rajesh Singla, fund manager & CEO, Alpha AMC, said this was largely due to factors such as elevated crude prices amid Hormuz-related supply risks, a weak rupee, firm U.S. bond yields, profit-booking and rotation towards AI-led North Asian markets. PTI

'India has no excess capacity, bans forced-labour imports'

Mr. Goyal's remarks come even as U.S.T.R levied 10% 'forced labour' tariff on India imports and is in the process of investigating country for structural excess capacity, which may result in more tariffs

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal told the G20 Trade Ministers meet in the U.S. India did not have structural excess capacity in sectors identified by Washington and it had taken steps to ban import of goods made using forced labour.

This comes at a time when the U.S. had already levied a 10% tariff on India for not doing enough to stop imports of goods made using forced labour, and is now probing it and other countries for structural excess capacity which could invite more tariffs.

On both issues, Mr. Goyal said steps must not be unilateral and be compliant with World Trade Organization (WTO) rules.

"Shri Piyush Goyal participated in the concluding day of the G20 Trade Ministers' Meeting in Milwaukee and spoke in sessions on structural excess capacity and production, updating the Most-Favoured-Nation principle, ending forced labour in global supply chains and the closing session," the Commerce Ministry said in a release.

The G20 Presidency is held by the U.S. for 2026.



Trade tangle: Goyal during a meeting with United States Trade Representative Jamieson Greer. PTI

On forced labour

The Office of the U.S. Trade Representative (USTR) had in July levied additional tariffs on 60 countries, including India, as a result of its probe into whether the countries had done enough to stop the import of goods made using forced labour.

Tariff on imports from India was set at 10%.

On ending forced labour in global supply chains, Mr. Goyal said India's commitment to the elimination of forced labour is "absolute and unconditional".

"He noted Article 23 of the Constitution prohibits forced labour as a fundamental right, enforceable by the Supreme Court," it added. "He said India ratified International Labour Organization (ILO) Conventions 29 and 105 and, in July, amended Foreign Trade Policy to prohibit import of goods produced using forced labour."

'No unilateral actions'

He said steps at the border must be based on "specific and verifiable evidence rather than presumptions about entire countries, regions or sectors" and must respect due process and WTO rules, adding ILO remains the competent, universal and tripartite body for labour standards.

"India supports the objective of eliminating forced labour and voluntary exchange of good practices among G20 members, provided such cooperation does not involve monitoring of members, create new obligations or result in information being used as a basis for unilateral trade action," Mr. Goyal said.

No excess capacity

The USTR is also in the process of probing 60 countries structural excess capacity and production and if this was hurting the U.S. economy. This could result in additional tariffs on imports from India.

On structural excess capacity and output, he Mr. said India was the fastest-growing large economy in the world, with an economy driven by local demand and is building manufacturing value chains "from design to finished goods".

"He said India's manufacturing capacity serves its domestic and global needs and that, in the sectors identified by the G20 Presidency, India does not have structural excess capacity," the release said.

Mr. Goyal said India shares the concerns of many G20 members that trade-distorting support in some economies can lead to "dumping and predatory pricing".

'WTO-compliant steps'

However, he emphasised such concerns were addressed via steps consistent with the WTO, such as anti-dumping and countervailing duties, based on evidence and subject to judicial review.

"He emphasised industrial capacity in itself is not the issue while distortions can arise where geographical concentration of production is driven by hidden subsidies and support.Diversification of production and supply chains is a legitimate objective but cannot be used as a pretext for measures outside WTO rules or for shifting the burden of adjustment onto developing countries, which must retain policy space to industrialise."

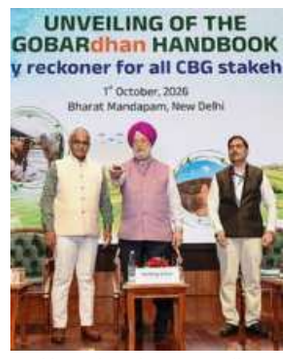
GOBARdhan eyes 10-fold increase in CBG output: Puri

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The ₹23,731-crore GOBARdhan scheme aims to drive a 10-fold increase in compressed biogas (CBG) production, save more than ₹40,000 crore in fuel imports, add over ₹75,000 crore to GDP and create more than 1.5 lakh jobs, as the government seeks to turn agricultural and organic waste into a new source of domestic energy.

Speaking at the formal launch of the scheme, Oil Minister Hardeep Singh Puri said the scheme provides capital assistance as well as guaranteed offtake of the renewable fuel made by processing organic waste such as agricultural residue, animal dung, food waste and other biomass.

Capital support plus guaranteed offtake is likely to lift CBG (essentially methane-rich gas) from current 0.4 million standard cubic metre per day to 4-6 mmscmd, he said, hoping this would help in achieving the target of raising share of natural gas – a cleaner-burning, lower-pollution fuel – in energy basket to 15% by 2030 from the current 6-7%.



Puri launches the GOBARdhan Scheme, at Bharat Mandapam, in New Delhi. PIB VIA PTI

Mr. Puri said the programme would help turn farmers from "Annadatas to also being the Urjadatas".

The scheme provides capital assistance of up to ₹30 crore per CBG project across the two eligible capital-support components. For greenfield plants, assistance is set at ₹1.25 crore per tonne per day (TPD) of eligible CBG capacity. Brownfield projects can receive support at 50% of the applicable greenfield rate for additional capacity created through fresh investment.

Plant upgrades

Existing biogas plants upgraded to make CBG can get ₹0.60 crore/TPD, subject to a ₹5-crore project ceiling. To make CBG projects commercially viable, the Centre is offering producers assured offtake of up to 100% eligible output at an administered price of ₹2,110 per million British thermal units - equivalent to about ₹98/ kg.

Decoding lifetime value for revenue visibility in auto component orders

Balasubramanyam C. P.
CHENNAI

When an auto-component maker announces a ₹2,000-crore order win, investors want to know how much will translate into revenue – and when.

The answer is not evident from the headline number. Component suppliers often win contracts for a vehicle platform's life with volumes ramping up, peaking and then tapering. This is why some firms use lifetime value (LTV) metric than annualised order value to measure revenue.

LTV is the estimated total sales a supplier expects from a vehicle programme over its production life.

Rane (Madras), for instance, shifted from annualised business wins to LTV in the June quarter. In its Q1 FY27 earnings call, the firm said it benchmarked the practice against Indian and global peers as most programmes ran for more than six years. It reported ₹2,040 crore of new business on LTV basis.

A Rane official told *The Hindu* that LTV is derived from the expected programme life and estimated OEM volumes when the order is secured. Dividing LTV by programme duration, it said, would not yield a meaningful annual figure because volumes vary over the programme.

Global suppliers use the metric too. Autoliv said in its 2025 annual report that delivery contracts typically cover a vehicle model's life, generally 5-7 years. Its LTV estimates factor in prices and production volumes while the typical lead time from order intake to start of production is one to three years.



Packing dilemma: Staff pack commercial vehicles parts inside an auto component manufacturing facility in Rajkot .REUTERS

For investors, LTV provides visibility on the long-term business pipeline. But it does not answer the immediate question: when does the revenue arrive?

Consider two programmes: one with an LTV of ₹1,000 crore over 10 years and another of ₹700 crore over three years. The first has larger LTV but the second could generate revenue faster.

A Chennai-based chartered accountant with more than 15 years of practice, who reviewed the issue for *The Hindu*, said LTV indicates the size of a long-term programme but does not provide sufficient near-term revenue visibility by itself. Investors should ideally see LTV alongside programme duration, start of production (SOP), annualised/peak value and revenue ramp-up, the CA said. Customer-volume assumptions and other conditions also matter.

Dividing LTV by years

Rane's ₹2,040-crore LTV divided by six years gives ₹340 crore a year. But that is only an average not a revenue forecast. Volumes can be lower during ramp-up, peak in the middle and decline thereafter.

Pratik Kothari of Unique PMS, who raised the issue during Rane's earnings call, noted the firm earlier disclosed peak order value and programme duration separately. Investors can still "divide by 6 and get annual/peak value", he said.

Mr. Kothari does not see the change as an attempt to inflate order wins.

"There is no perception building," he said, adding there was "nothing sensational about it".

Rane official said meaningful revenue from orders typically begins 12-24 months after the award, with the full contribution usually coming over the following 3-6 years, sometimes longer. The firm does not provide year-by-year guidance on commercially-sensitive parameters as SOPs, ramp-ups and customer platform decisions can change.

There is no industry-wide disclosure practice. Suprajit Engineering, for instance, disclosed both, reporting in June 2026 new contracts worth about $12 million annually with an estimated LTV of $75 million.

UPI volume jumps 27% to touch 145 bn in first half of FY27

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

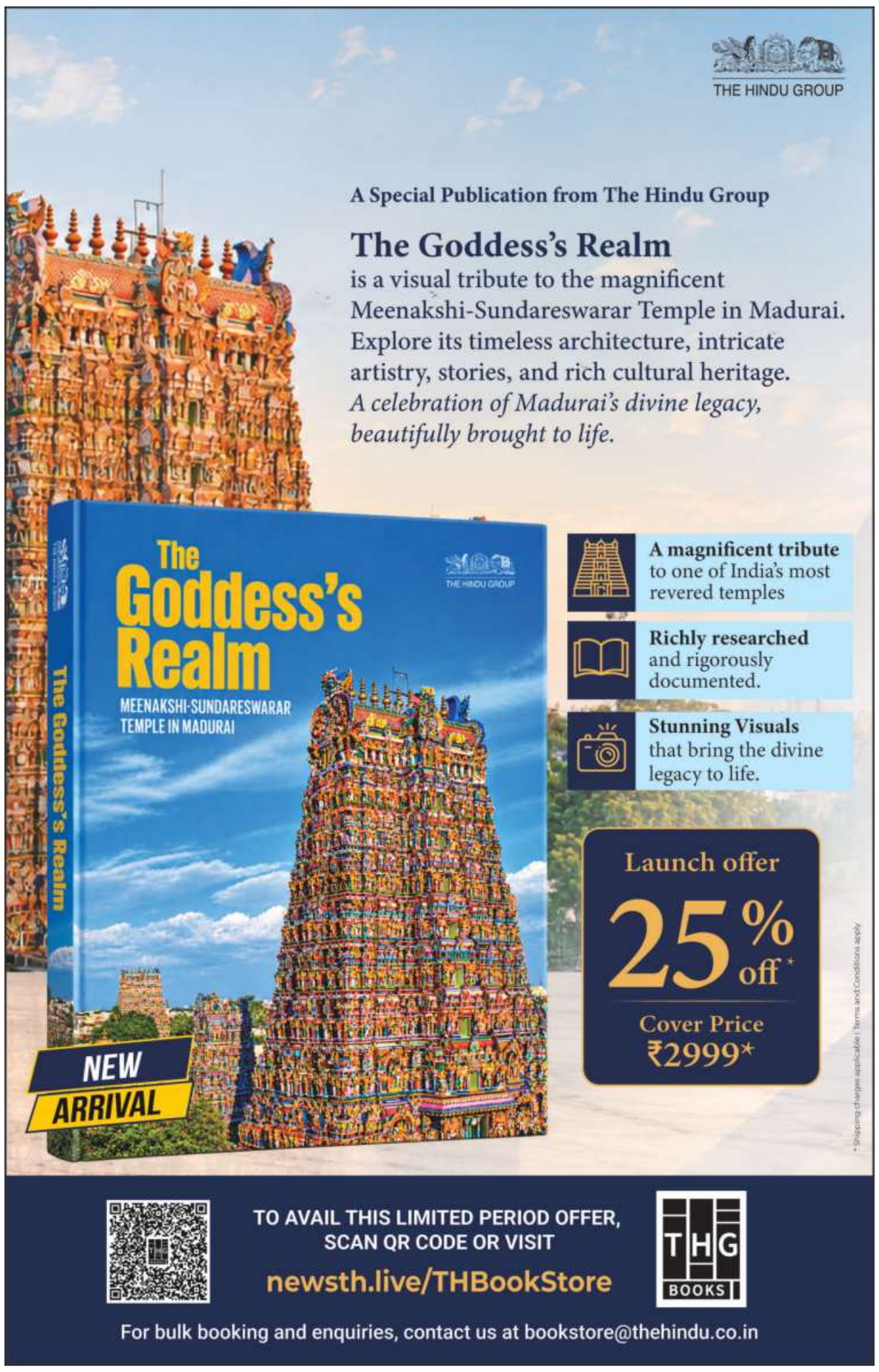
UPI transactions through popular Unified Payments Interface (UPI) in volume terms have witnessed a 27% jump to around 145 billion in the first half of the current fiscal year.

This is against UPI volume 114 billion during April-September quarter of the previous financial year, as per data released by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI).

However, the UPI transaction during the value term rose a slightly lower rate of 20% to ₹177 lakh crore as against ₹148 lakh crore during the first six months of the current financial year. As regards September, the UPI volume moderated by 1.7% to 24.07 billion compared to 24.5 billion last month.

On a month-on-month basis, value, too, declined 1.5% to ₹29.37 lakh crore against ₹29.82 lakh crore in August. The figures come a fortnight ahead of the implementation of the new merchant discount rate fee on high-value UPI payments for merchants.

Industry watchers attributed the dip to the fact August has 31 days versus 30 in September and pointed out average transactions/day were higher in September at 802 million versus 791 million in August. NPCI, an initiative of the RBI and the Indian Banks' Association, is an umbrella organisation for retail payments and settlement systems in India. It runs UPI used for real-time payments between peers or at merchants' end while making purchases.



GENEVA

At least 5,700 killed or wounded in Haiti gang violence this year: UN



AP

Haiti's gang violence crisis has left at least 5,700 people dead or wounded this year while more than 1,000 women and girls have been raped, UN rights chief Volker Turk said on Friday. He said the casualties and rapes and 230 kidnappings had been recorded by the UN mission in Haiti up to September 11. AFP

KYIV

Ukraine denies facing crisis with F-16 over maintenance and parts



AP

Ukraine on Friday denied that it was facing maintenance and supply problems with its F-16 fighter jets, insisting that it can keep them in the air throughout winter. The *Wall Street Journal* reported this week that delays in maintenance and a shortage of parts had grounded more than half of Ukraine's fleet. AFP

WASHINGTON

FBI arrests U.S. govt. employee for 'trying to support Yemeni Houthis'



AP

The U.S. Justice Department said on Thursday that Ashton Hamed Ellaboudy, a Department of Energy electrical engineer, has been arrested by the Federal Bureau of Investigation on charges of providing support to the Houthi rebels, including by buying materials for home-made explosives and travelling to Yemen. AP

PARIS

BAPS says it didn't ask Eiffel Tower to remove women employees



AFP

The BAPS (Bochasanwasi Akshar Purushottam Swaminarayan Sanstha) has said investigations have established it did not request female employees be "removed or excluded" during its delegation's visit to the Eiffel Tower in Paris. The group reiterated its concern for employees affected by the events surrounding the visit. PTI

Russian strikes snarl traffic on Kyiv bridges in a new disruption tactic

Russian aerial attacks overnight force full or partial closure of three of Kyiv's six road bridges across the Dnipro river; Ukraine's Foreign Minister says Kyiv has received separate partial-truce proposals from the U.S., India, Turkiye, and Egypt

Associated Press
KYIV

Russian aerial attacks forced the partial closure on Friday of three bridges across the Dnipro river in Kyiv, the Ukrainian capital's Mayor said, in Moscow's latest effort to disrupt life in the city.

Meanwhile, Ukraine's top diplomat said officials have received separate proposals for a partial truce with Russia from the United States, India, Turkiye, and Egypt. The proposals envision halting attacks on energy infrastructure which have caused fuel shortages in Russia and power outages in Ukraine, and on Black Sea shipping needed to get vital grain exports to world markets.



Choked roads: Cars stuck in a traffic jam near a bridge in Kyiv following overnight jet drone strikes on Friday. REUTERS

The Russian strikes forcing the full or partial closure of three of Kyiv's six road bridges caused traffic logjams and appeared to be a new tactic in its campaign to torment the city's residents. Previously, Russia has hit apartment blocks, supermarket warehouses, gas stations, data centres, and other targets, in an escalation of attacks.

Civilians "are bearing the brunt of this war", the UN High Commissioner for Human Rights, Volker Turk, said in Geneva on Friday.

"The war in Ukraine is a human rights catastrophe that is growing and intensifying by the week, causing unfathomable pain to civilians," he said. "Across Ukraine, people are living in constant dread."

Russia fired more than 100 drones at Ukraine overnight, striking Kyiv and eight other regions, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said. Almost half of the drones were the jet-powered type that are especially hard to stop, he said.

A drone hit a high-rise apartment block in Kyiv, killing one person, he said. At least four people were reported wounded elsewhere.

Mr. Zelenskyy repeated his appeal for foreign countries to close loopholes in international sanctions on Russia and to add more restrictions on its trade.

He said Russia's drones and missiles are "critically dependent" on foreign components.

"Every Russian drone can actually be stopped right at the production line," Mr. Zelenskyy said.

G7 nations agree to release 100 million barrels of oil

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

The Group of Seven industrial nations said on Friday that they plan to release 100 million barrels of oil and fuel products in the coming weeks, starting with "substantial" amounts of diesel after the fuel recently hit record high prices in the United States.

President Donald Trump said the diesel release would happen "immediately," while a G7 statement promised a "front-loaded substantial release" of diesel within the next 20 days.

Mr. Trump and his Republican Party face pressure to address surging prices ahead of the November 3 midterm elections, and Mr. Trump announced the action on Friday on social media. The President's approval ratings on the economy hit a new low, according to an AP-NORC poll, as the Iran war and his trade battles have increased U.S. prices for oil and other goods.



Emmanuel Macron

Record high

Fuel prices in the U.S. and abroad have soared during the eight-month-long war, a cost Mr. Trump has repeatedly said is worth it for making sure Iran does not obtain nuclear weapons. The national average for a gallon of diesel in the U.S. was $6.37 on Friday, according to AAA, after hitting a record $6.52 on September 22.

France holds the rotating presidency of the G7 group and made the announcement in a statement released after videoconference talks that Mr. Macron presided over. The International Energy Agency will coordinate the effort to combat soaring fuel prices.

"We will implement our commitments with a coordinated release through the IEA of 100 million barrels (MB) to begin immediately over 4 months, including a front-loaded substantial diesel release within the first 20 days by G7 members and partners," the statement said.

Netanyahu warns of 'heavy price' over flydubai incident

Agence France-Presse
JERUSALEM

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu warned on Friday that Israel would impose a "very heavy price" on any power behind the flydubai incident, without offering evidence that any country was responsible.

"As time passes, the picture is becoming clearer: The attacker underwent Islamist radicalisation. He came to crash the plane with all passengers on board," Mr. Netanyahu said.

"We are investigating whether he was sent, and whoever sent him will pay a very heavy price," Mr. Netanyahu said of the co-pilot assailant.

Mr. Netanyahu did not identify any country as a potential culprit but for years has been quick to point the finger at Iran.

U.S. President Donald Trump had said that he was "hearing" that Iran was involved and that it will "be hit very hard" if so.

Pakistan govt. in talks with Imran Khan's Opposition party as protest threat looms

Agence France-Presse
ISLAMABAD

Pakistan's government and the party of jailed former Prime Minister Imran Khan held talks on Friday over planned protests by his supporters that threaten to bring Islamabad to a standstill.

In anticipation of the protests calling for Mr. Khan's release, shipping containers requisitioned by authorities have stood for weeks along major highways and at key entry points to the Pakistani capital to stop arriving demonstrators.



Restricted access: Vehicles drive past shipping containers blocking a road towards the Red Zone area in Islamabad on Friday. AFP

President Asif Ali Zardari's office said representatives from the government and Mr. Khan's Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI) party were to meet on Friday to discuss the protests, planned for Sunday after being pushed back from September 27.

State broadcaster *PTV* reported the meetings had concluded for the day and would resume on Saturday.

In a statement on Friday, PTI said it was prepared to go ahead with the protests, but party official Haleem Adil Sheikh said negotiations could move forward if the government showed flexibility on demands including the release of Mr. Khan's sisters, who were arrested last month.

"We are talking to the government today in a positive spirit," he said.

Taiwan receives two U.S. F-16Vs and awaits additional fighter jets

Associated Press
BANGKOK

Taiwan on Friday received the first two of 65 F-16V fighter jets ordered from the U.S., the island's Air Force said, following years of delays.

The two F-16V Block 70 jets landed at Chihhang Air Base in Taitung. There are 63 more to be delivered. The self-ruled island, which is also claimed by Beijing as part of its territory, placed an order for the F-16Vs in 2019.

Taiwan largely purchases arms from the U.S., its largest unofficial ally, to boost its defences in the face of a military threat from China. China sends fighter jets and ships toward the island almost daily. Taiwan's Defence Minister said on Tuesday that the island remains in continuous discussions with the U.S. about their weapons sales.

The shipment is the first in a long list of backlogged U.S. orders worth almost $30 billion.

Sport

Dogra and Nasir dig in to help J&K take the lead

IRANI CUP

Vivek Krishnan
SRINAGAR

By the middle of the afternoon session on day two of the Irani Cup fixture at the Sher-i-Kashmir Stadium, the faces in the Jammu & Kashmir dugout appeared to have turned glum. The spectators, barring a few quips towards Rest of India skipper Rishabh Pant, had also fallen silent.

It reflected J&K's plight, having been reduced to 166 for eight. It was still 71 runs adrift of RoI's first-innings total of 237 with just two wickets in hand.

Barely an hour later, the mood swayed. The smiles in the J&K camp returned. So did the cheers of the sparse crowd. It was all thanks to a rearguard 64-run partnership between Paras Dogra (75, 143b, 6x4, 1x6) and Lone Nasir (64, 58b, 8x4, 3x6) for the ninth wicket, enabling J&K, which was 21 for two overnight, to finish its first innings on 278 and secure a 41-run lead.

Choudhary scalps five

The recovery ended up overshadowing left-arm pacer Mukesh Choudhary's figures of 19-2-78-5 for the visitors. The day drew to a close with RoI reaching 24 for one in its second essay.

Dogra had been gritty until the fall of the host's eighth wicket, accumulating his runs quietly and letting Abdul Samad (57, 88b, 5x4, 1x6) hog the limelight in a fifth-wicket stand of 101. But once the 41-year-old was confronted with the threat of running out of partners, he acted with greater intent.

As runs started to flow more frequently, Pant started feeling the pinch. He resorted to a barrage of short balls from his quicks, but Dogra and Nasir, aware of what was coming given the field set, rocked back and feasted with a flurry of boundaries.

Dogra eventually pulled Choudhary awkwardly to Mukesh Kumar at fine-leg. Even then, Nasir, who struck thrice on the opening day, maintained the onslaught with a 48-run partnership alongside Sunil Kumar for the last wicket. Nasir treated Mukesh with special disdain, smashing his half-trackers for three maximums.

The scores:

Rest of India — 1st innings: 237.

Jammu & Kashmir — 1st innings: Qamran Iqbal c Pant b Choudhary 24, Shubham Pundir c Pant b Choudhary 1, Umar Nazir c Pant b Akash 4, Shubham Khajuria b Choudhary 4, Paras Dogra c Mukesh b Choudhary 75, Abdul Samad c Sangwan b Mukesh 57, Kanhaiya Wadhawan c Smaran b Choudhary 12, Abid Mushtaq lbw b Mukesh 0, Sahil Lotra c Sangwan b Akash 2, Lone Nasir lbw b Akash 64, Sunil Kumar (not out) 2; Extras (b-12, lb-3, w-12, nb-6): 33; Total (in 64.2 overs): 278.

Fall of wickets: 1-16, 2-21, 3-36, 4-37, 5-138, 6-156, 7-157, 8-166, 9-230.

RoI bowling: Mukesh 17-2-84-2, Choudhary 19-2-78-5, Akash 14.2-3-43-3, Manav 9-1-32-0, Saransh 5-0-26-0.

RoI — 2nd innings: Shikhar Mohan c Wadhawan b Sunil 2, Sanat Sangwan (batting) 10, Sudip Gharami (batting) 10; Extras (b-1, nb-1): 2; Total (for one wkt. in 15 overs): 24

Fall of wicket: 1-8.

J&K bowling: Umar 6-2-10-0, Sunil 7-3-9-1, Nasir 2-0-4-0.



Timely: Skipper Dogra and Nasir notched up half-centuries to bail J&K out and give the host first innings honours. IMRAN NISSAR

With another's jersey, Nasir makes his mark

Vivek Krishnan
SRINAGAR

In three previous First Class appearances for Jammu & Kashmir, Lone Nasir hadn't picked up a wicket. He had scored all of 115 runs, his best being a knock of 44.

His selection, therefore, for the Irani Cup fixture against Rest of India was unexpected. So much so that J&K didn't have a jersey adorning his name and number in place for the game.

If there was a way to announce himself, the 29-year-old all-rounder couldn't have done much better than snare three wickets on the opening day and follow it up with an entertaining 64 off 58 balls. Not for much longer will he have to wear a shirt with Vivrant Sharma's name taped on his back.

"My selection was at the last minute. It was unexpected. I wasn't sure I would be picked even though I had done well in the trial games," Nasir said at the close of day two.

Nasir's all-round show has put J&K in a strong position.

When he came in to bat at No. 10, the host was teetering on the abyss at 166 for eight. But his 64-run stand with skipper Paras Dogra turned things around. "Such situations are not new to me. I have taken the J&K under-23 team out of such situations many times. The belief was there".

INCREDIBLE TURNAROUND

Sujeet's Houdini act wins him the top prize in 65kg wrestling



PTI

Sujeet Kalkal underlined his growing supremacy in the men's 65kg category by clinching the Asiad gold, beating an Olympic champion on the way to the title and erasing a massive 2-9 deficit in the final against Tajikistan's Kudiev Abdulmazhid. The Indian wrestler defeated Japan's Olympic champ Kotaro Kiyooka in the semifinal.

FOURTH TIME LUCKY

Nethra Kumanan claims bronze in women's dinghy



REUTERS

Nethra Kumanan clinched the women's dinghy bronze, securing her first podium finish in her fourth Asian Games appearance. The 29-year-old two-time Olympian logged 14 points in all (seven each in the final and qualification) behind winner Sophia Montgomery (5) of Thailand and silver medallist Jania Ang (13) of Singapore.

ON THE PODIUM

Harshita and Shital clinch the third spot in skiff sailing



REUTERS

The Indian duo of Harshita Tomar and Shital Verma won the bronze medal in the women's skiff sailing event at the Asian Games. Harshita and Shital finished the competition with 24 net points and 28 total points across nine races to finish ahead of China, which was disqualified in races two, six and eight. Skiffs are small light boats.

THE PAKISTAN CHALLENGE

Shutting out the outside noise part of professional sport: Kanitkar



PTI

Frankly, there is pressure in every international game. So we need to be in our zone and do our best. Shutting out all the outside noise is part of professional sport. So that's what we'll look to do — Hrishikesh Kanitkar, India's batting coach, on the eve of the Asian Games men's cricket final against Pakistan.

India women baulk Chinese pressure to corner glory

The players end a 44-year wait for gold even as they punch their tickets to the 2028 LA Olympics, following a defensive masterclass led by Savita under the post to protect Lalremsiami's brilliant goal

ASIAN GAMES

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

Forty four years. That's how long Indian women's hockey has waited for this moment. Winning the Asian Games, defeating China 1-0 in the final on Friday, was the final box ticked for the year by a group that bears no resemblance to the one that started 2026.

The final against the defending champion, a team the Indians have not beaten in the last two years, was never expected to be easy and for many, it would have been downright improbable to think of a victory. The opponent was, after all, also the current Olympic silver medallist.

The Gifu Prefectural Green Stadium is, literally, in the middle of nowhere. There is a grand total of one road leading up to it and India's final hustle for the gold and a spot at the LA Olympics was off to the worst start possible, delayed by an accident en route that forced the match to be pushed back by an hour.

Once they reached the ground and play started, though, there was little to suggest the extended wait had any effect on either team. Physically, the Chinese are taller, stronger, more imposing. With the stick and the ball, the Indians were niftier.

Most importantly, the attitude screamed. There was none of the pulling back hesitation of old. Sakshi Rana, Lalremsiami and Navneet Kaur were up front and in the Chinese circle at every opportunity.

One such moment came in the 10th minute when Sakshi put the ball through and Lalremsiami, in one fell swoop, reversed the ball into the net for a 1-0 lead. There would be no change in the scoreline till the final whistle but for the next 50 minutes, it was a defensive masterclass from Savita & Co. The former captain, under the bar, stood tall as everything was blocked, cleared, and tackled with discipline. There were five penalty corners conceded and a stroke too, but nothing worked for China as Shilpi Dabas, Baljeet Singh and Ishika threw themselves at everything.



See you in LA! India emerged as the new continental giant and also booked its place in the Summer Games. R.V. MOORTHY

A goalmouth melee resulted in a penalty stroke for China in the 23rd minute but there was no getting past Savita on this day, diving correctly to her left and saving. That moment proved why there is still no replacement for her even after 15 years of national duty. The Indian defence changed the momentum, the Indians suddenly believing it was their day.

To China's credit, there was no breakdown. Its system held till the very end. But there was only so much a system, as perfect as it may be, could do against a group of women willing to put their bodies on the line and fighting for every inch of and on the turf.

Five years ago, another Indian team had held off an Australian side for 38 minutes with a single goal lead.

That famous win took India to the Olympic semifinals for the first time ever. Seven from that group were on the pitch on Friday. Along with a younger and bolder bunch, they scripted a memorable triumph.

Medals table

	Country	G	S	B	T
1	China	162	81	73	316
2	Japan	72	83	85	240
3	South Korea	33	39	62	134
4	Uzbekistan	20	23	22	65
5	**India**	**16**	**25**	**35**	**76**

The result (final): China 0 lost to India 1 (Lalremsiami 10).

Lovlina, Parveen and Ankush make it a hat-trick of golds

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

Lovlina Borgohain, Parveen Hooda and Ankush Panghal won their respective bouts to clinch three gold and take India to the top of boxing medal tally at the Asian Games here on Friday.

Lovlina began the charge with a golden present to herself and the country on her 29th birthday, dominating across all three rounds against China's reigning Asian champion Ziyi Bao in the 75kg for a 5-0 win.

Lovlina became only the second Indian woman boxer to win an Asian Games gold, after Mary Kom, but she was not to be the only one at this edition. "There was a time when I thought of giving up boxing but then decided against it. Today it feels surreal to win a gold here. Being compared to a legend like Mary Kom is a motivation and I never thought I would gift myself and the country a gold, this one's very special," Lovlina said.

Parveen completed her own redemption arc with a 3-2 victory against Paris Olympic bronze medallist and current Asian champion Chen Nien-chin of Taiwan in the 65kg final.

Having won bronze last time around only to see it taken away due to a whereabouts clause failure ban, Parveen's gold was a vindication of both her mental and physical tenacity.

Ankush's 4-0 triumph over Korea's Kim Minseong in the 80kg capped a fruitful outing for the boxing contingent that finished with three gold and as many bronze.



All that glitters is gold: Lovlina, Parveen and Ankush ensured India's best-ever return from the boxing ring. R.V. MOORTHY & AP

Plucky Indian trio breaks Korea's hegemony in recurve team event

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

Kumkum Mohod pulled back the string, stood still and released the arrow. It landed inside the circle for 10 points but while the Indian supporters erupted in joy, the archers themselves were restrained, waiting for an official confirmation.

That confirmation not only ended one of the longest Asian Games winning streaks but also etched the names of Kumkum, Kirti and Ankita Bhakat forever in the annals of archery history by winning India's first-ever recurve team gold 5-3 against Korea at the Okazaki Chuo Sogo Park Multipurpose Square here on Friday.

This was Korea's first defeat in the event since 1998 as Lee Yunji, Kang Chaeyoung and Oh Yejin came up short in their bid for an eighth straight Asian Games gold. Korea and India scored identical 54 and 56 points each in the first two sets to be tied 2-2.

Turning point

The third set changed everything. Korea started the set and clearly the pressure got to it. Yunji shot a couple of eights while the other two shot one apiece for Korea to total 51, its lowest all week.

In reply, Kirti and Kumkum shot a 10 each and an eight and a nine respectively, Ankita had two nines and the team totalled 55 to take the set and lead 4-2.

Thereafter, it was only a matter of staying level. In the fourth and final set, Kirti started with an eight but it carried an asterisk, to be confirmed later.

Kumkum's final 10 was followed by a closer look by the judges. An eight would take the match into shoot-off; it was adjudicated a nine and it was all over.

The gold only burnished the trio's reputation after it had already made history by reaching the final for the first time with a 5-1 victory against China, winning the first two sets easily for a 4-0 lead before sharing points in the third.

Minutes later, Kumkum paired up with Dhiraj Bommadevara to come from behind and defeat Japan 5-3 in the semifinals of the mixed event after the host had taken lead in the first set.

However, a couple of eights in the second set hurt India's chances in the final against China, having to end with a silver (3-5). Dhiraj also won silver with the men's team of Neeraj Chauhan and Yashdeep Bhoge, going down 1-5 to Korea in the final after a dominant 6-0 victory against Iran in the last four.



Into the record books: Kumkum, Ankita and Kirti on top of the podium after a remarkable show. REUTERS



Overjoyed: Kumkum and Dhiraj celebrate their mixed team silver medal finish. REUTERS



Happy times: Dhiraj, Yashdeep and Neeraj finished with the men's team silver. PTI

THE INDIA SHOW

A look at some Indian performances on Friday:

Archery: Recurve (finals): Women's team: bt South Korea; Men's team: lost to South Korea; Mixed team: lost to China.

Boxing: Finals: Women: 75kg: Lovlina bt Ziyi (Chn); 65kg: Parveen bt Nien-chin (Tpe); Men: 80kg: Ankush bt Minseong (Kor).

Golf: Round 3: Individual: Women: Pranavi (first), Diksha and Aditi (T18); Team: Second; Men: Veer (10th), Saptak (11th), Yuvraj (T23); Team: Sixth.

Hockey: Women (final): bt China 1-0.

Sailing: Women's dinghy: Nethra (bronze); Men's dinghy: Vishnu (fourth overall).

Sepaktakraw: Men's quadrant (semifinal): lost to Japan 0-2, bagged bronze.

Volleyball: Men (classification match 5th-8th): bt South Korea 3-1.

Wrestling: Men's freestyle: 65kg (final): Sujeet bt Abdulmazhid (Tjk); 125kg (1/8 final): Rajat lost to Kassimbek (Kaz); Women: 50kg (bronze medal match): Dipanshi lost to Bayanova (Kaz); 76kg (1/8 final): Priya lost to Kyzy (Kgz).

HI official accused of harassment, sent home

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

On field, the Indian women's hockey team stepped out to create history against China and win the Asian Games for only the second time and the first since 1982. Off it, yet another international embarrassment rocked Indian hockey with Indian umpires manager Gurinder Singh Sangha being sent home following complaints of misbehaviour and harassment.

"Yes Sangha has been sent back. There were complaints of him harassing foreign officials officiating here," confirmed a senior official.

INDIANS IN ACTION

A look at some Indian players/teams who will compete on Saturday (all times IST):

Archery: Recurve individual: Women's quarterfinal: Kumkum vs. Chaeyoung (Kor), 5.30 a.m.; semifinals, 6.30 a.m. onwards; medal matches, 7.05 a.m. onwards; Men's quarterfinal: Dhiraj vs. Sadikov (Uzb), 9.30 a.m.; Neeraj vs. Dorji (Bhu), 10.15 a.m.; semifinals, 10.30 a.m. onwards; medal matches, 11.05 a.m. onwards.

Cricket: Men (final): vs. Pakistan, 10 a.m.

Hockey: Men (final): vs. Malaysia, 3.30 p.m.

Volleyball: Men (classification match 5th-6th): vs. Thailand, 9.30 a.m.

Wrestling: 1/8 finals: Men's freestyle: 74kg: Sagar vs. Tumur-Ochir (Mgl), 7.20 a.m.; 97kg: Deepak vs. Junpeng (Chn), 7.25 a.m.; 57kg: Aman vs. TBC, 8.25 a.m.; Women: 57kg: Manisha vs. Youngjin (Kor), 7.50 a.m.; 53kg: Antim vs. Shugyla (Kaz), 8.05 a.m.

Excitement in the air as India braces for Brazilian challenge at Salt Lake

It will be interesting to see the side Ancelotti fields, with the coach viewing the tour as part of a rebuilding process following a poor World Cup

FOOTBALL

Amitabha Das Sharma
KOLKATA

A new chapter in Indian football is set to unfold at the Salt Lake Stadium here on Saturday as the National team takes on five-time World champion Brazil in a high-profile international friendly.

The gulf in pedigree and ranking is stark, with India placed 138th in the world and Brazil sixth, but the occasion offers the host a rare opportunity to test itself against one of football's most celebrated sides.

For Indian football, the match carries significance beyond the result. Having missed out on qualification for next year's AFC Asian Cup, the Blue Tigers will be keen to make the most of an occasion that has generated unprecedented attention. Brazil's first visit to India has sparked enormous excitement among fans.

For many supporters, the encounter will be an opportunity to witness the *Selecao* from up close. Much of the intrigue will centre on the combination Carlo Ancelotti chooses to field, with the celebrated Italian coach viewing the tour as part of a rebuilding process following a disappointing World Cup campaign.

Brazil has considerable attacking firepower, with Vinicius Junior, Endrick, Estevao and Pedro among the options available to Ancelotti. Marquinhos, Bruno Guimaraes and Gabriel Magalhaes could also feature, depending on the gaffer's plans.

On paper, the contest appears heavily weighted in Brazil's favour. Its squad is packed with players accustomed to competing at the highest level in Europe. India, by contrast, has assembled a squad largely drawn from the Indian Super League.

Yet, the match offers the home players an opportunity to compete against elite opposition.

India did punch above its weight in the previous friendly, holding Panama to a 1-1 draw last week. Whether Ryan Williams, Manvir Singh, Ashique Kuruniyan, Anwar Ali and Apuia can produce another spirited performance against the South American giant remains to be seen. With the stadium expected to be packed, India will hope to make the occasion a memorable one.



In high spirits: The Brazilian team members will be eager to come up with a dazzling display on their first visit to the country. K.R. DEEPAK

Brazil has considerable attacking firepower, with the likes of Vinicius, Endrick, Estevao and Pedro in its ranks.
The Blue Tigers will hope to make the occasion a memorable one in front of what is expected to be a packed house



Bhute-Praful stand stonewalls Aussies



Grit: Mulani played a crucial role in thwarting the visitor. X@CAP

AUS-A IN INDIA

Abhishek Saini
PUDUCHERRY

On a day when Yash Rathod (80, 138b, 8x4) put a lean run behind him and Tushar Deshpande (52, 119b, 4x4, 1x6) reminded of his batting credentials, it was Nachiket Bhute and Praful Hinge who emerged the unlikely heroes and secured a draw for India-A against Australia-A in the second 'Test' at the Siechem Stadium on Friday.

Australia-A had resigned itself to fate because of Rathod and Shams Mulani (29, 131b, 2x4), who put up 85 for the eighth wicket, a partnership that lasted 36 overs, including 16 against the second new ball.

But Liam Scott (five for 37) broke open a window with his skiddy length deliveries that zipped low pinned them both, leaving Praful and Bhute to play out the final three of the mandatory final 15. Australia-A threw the kitchen sink at them, packing 10 fielders in catching positions, but still had its victory march stalled. In denying the final wicket, Praful and Bhute also got a 1-0 series victory in the bag. No less was the contribution from Deshpande in the morning session that instilled the hope of a draw. He cut and lofted Jhye Richardon for two boundaries to begin the day. The outcome could have been different had Jason Sangha grabbed his edge off Corey Rocchiccioli on 23.

The scores: Australia-A 358 & 173/4 decl. drew with India-A 167 & 310/9 in 103 overs (Tushar Deshpande 52, Yash Rathod 80, Liam Scott 5/37). **PoM**: Sam Harper; **PoS**: Shams Mulani.

LIVE TELECAST

Irani Cup: day 3, JioHotstar, 9.30 a.m.

Cricket: Asian Games (Men): India vs Pakistan, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 10 a.m.

Formula One: Bahrain GP (Qualifying), F1 TV, F1 TV Pro App & FanCode, 1.30 p.m.

India vs West Indies: 3rd ODI, Star Sports 2 & JioHotstar, 2 p.m.

International Friendly: India vs Brazil, Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 7.30 p.m.

Nations League: Sony Sports Ten 2, 3, 5 & LIV, 9.30 p.m. & 12.15 a.m. (Sunday)

Asian Games: Sony Sports Ten 2, 5 & LIV, 6 a.m. (Sunday)

India ready for Brazil test, Jamil calls for support

Amitabha Das Sharma
KOLKATA

India head coach Khalid Jamil acknowledged the quality of the opposition ahead of his side's much-anticipated clash against Brazil, while stressing the importance of backing the national team.

"We are playing against a good team. It is our pleasure to play, but they also know that it is an important game," Jamil said ahead of the match. "We have prepared to the best of our ability. We want everyone to support India," he added.

Defender Anwar Ali echoed his coach's sentiments, describing the encounter as a "very big game" and urging the team to give everything on the pitch. "We just have to give our 100 percent so that whoever is watching, they can also follow us. We just have to do our best."

For India, the Brazil fixture represents a major occasion, with Jamil and Anwar both emphasising the need to embrace the challenge and give their all.



Hard at work: The Indians gear up for the big day. K.R. DEEPAK

I hope it will be an entertaining night for everyone: Ancelotti

Amitabha Das Sharma
KOLKATA

Brazil national team coach Carlo Ancelotti had words of praise for Indian football ahead of his side's much-anticipated clash, saying the country's passion for the sport was encouraging.

"It is an honour for us to be here with the national team. We know what it means to be involved with the national team, not just in football," Ancelotti told a packed media conference.

Expresses happiness

"We are happy to be here, to play against India and to show the quality of our players. We hope it will be an entertaining night for everyone at the stadium."

The Italian also backed India's ambitions of hosting a World Cup.

"The possibility of a World Cup in India would be fantastic. India is trying to compete in football as well, and I hope they can have a happy future in the sport," he said.

Ancelotti added that the match would help Brazil continue rebuilding as it begins a new cycle.



Exchanging pleasantries: Ancelotti greets his Indian counterpart Jamil. K.R. DEEPAK

Madhava Prasad and Athish hit centuries



Madhava Prasad.



Athish.

U-23 CRICKET

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu u-23 openers K.T.A. Madhava Prasad (150 batting, 302b, 20x4) and S.R. Athish (137, 203b, 19x4, 3x6) shone bright with centuries as Rest of India u-23 faced the heat on a day the sun was beating down at the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium here.

When the curtains were brought down on the second day – Friday – TN was well and truly in the ascendancy, sitting at 368 for one with an 189-run lead. The 250-run stand between Madhava Prasad and Athish deflated the hopes of the RoI bowlers, who employed different tactics only to get no returns for nearly five hours in total.

Madhava Prasad was content playing second fiddle to Athish for much of the first-wicket alliance. The right-hander used his feet well against the spinners, with one such move enabling him to bring up his ton. To join his opening partner in the century club, he reverse-swept left-arm tweaker Emanjot Singh Chahal with authority for a boundary.

Athish had luck on his side. The southpaw was dropped twice while inching closer to his hundred – by Angkrish Raghuvanshi at mid-on on 81 and 96 – and completed his milestone with a double over fine-leg off the last ball of the first session.

Emanjot broke the mammoth partnership, having Athish caught at backward short-leg.

Madhava Prasad and Kiran Karthikeyan (56 batting, 98b, 8x4) stayed unconquered at the end of a fruitful day for the home team.

The scores:
Rest of India u-23 179 vs. Tamil Nadu u-23 368/1 in 100 overs (S.R. Athish 137, K.T.A. Madhava Prasad 150 batting, Kiran Karthikeyan 56 batting).

Athish's manifestation comes true in some style

S. Shrivathsan
CHENNAI

S.R. Athish is brimming with confidence. He was so optimistic about delivering a top knock in the Tamil Nadu u-23-Rest of India u-23 game that he decided ahead of the fixture how he would "celebrate" the special moment.

The 22-year-old did not disappoint himself, notching up 137 while stitching 250 runs with fellow centurion K.T.A. Madhava Prasad for the first wicket here on Friday.

"A few days ago, my father shared a video of Shubman Gill's celebration. Mine was a preplanned celebration. I knew that something big would happen this match," said Athish, who will fight for an opening slot in the Tamil Nadu Ranji Trophy team.

"This innings will definitely give me confidence. It is a good start to the season. We will have to see if I get a chance... it will depend on the combination. If I get a chance, I will use it."

Paying more attention to the mental side of his game has allowed Athish to blossom. "In the last three months, I have been writing affirmations, visualising stuff and allocating time for meditation. I am seeing the results".

Will Gill & Co. test bench strength in the final ODI?

WI IN INDIA

S. Dipak Ragav
NEW CHANDIGARH

Playing in front of a home crowd is always special for a cricketer, even more so when one is privileged to lead the team. Add to this the player being in the form of their life, and the already sky-high expectations will reach stratospheric levels.

That is what awaits Shubman Gill when he marches his men into the Maharaja Yadavindra Singh Stadium for the third and final ODI against West Indies here on Saturday.

The India captain has been instrumental in the Men in Blue sealing the series with match-winning knocks in the first two games. The 27-year-old tore the West Indies bowling attack into smithereens with his 110 in Thiruvananthapuram before smashing a spectacular unbeaten 223 in Guwahati, where he made a mockery of a 406-run target.

Gill will now look to celebrate the venue's inaugural one-dayer in style, aiming to complete a clean sweep in his backyard.

While a 3-0 scoreline would be ideal, the skipper will know that every game his side plays over the next year is not merely about winning, but also about taking crucial preparatory steps towards the 2027 ODI World Cup.

In that context, it won't be surprising if the home team makes some changes to test its bench strength.

Mohammed Siraj has had a tough last few months, with sub-par performances in the Sri Lanka Tests against the Duleep Trophy final. Now that Prasidh Krishna is out due to injury, the management might be tempted to give the Hyderabad pacer a chance to regain form.

Similarly, Yashasvi Jaiswal is waiting in the wings, and it will be interesting to see who among the top four will make way for the left-hander if he is chosen.

Since the middle and lower order haven't had much to do, India should also consider challenging itself by posting a total and defending it now that the series is in the bag.

For West Indies, it has been a case of a job half-done in both matches. While the batters have held their end of the bargain, the bowlers have fallen short.

The key to containing a strong line-up is taking wickets up front, but once the pacers fail to deliver, the task gets progressively harder for the spinners. Another big talking point has been the pitches and how skewed they have been in favour of the willow-wielders. The visitors will hope for a more balanced surface to give themselves a chance to salvage pride.

Match starts at 2 p.m.



Making heads turn: Rohit and Gill wowed the Guwahati crowd in India's record run chase. FILE PHOTO: RITU RAJ KONWAR

> I mean, look, as a professional, that's (pay cuts) not what you want to hear before a series
>
> **DAREN SAMMY**
> West Indies head coach

SNAPSHOTS



It was that easy: Cancelo celebrates after scoring Portugal's early opener. AFP

Portugal wins without Ronaldo

PARIS: Portugal shrugged off the absence of Cristiano Ronaldo and turned on the style to win 4-2 in Denmark in the UEFA Nations League on Thursday, while Germany beat Serbia 2-0 to give Jurgen Klopp his first win as coach.
Wales beat Norway 2-1 in the same group in Cardiff, despite Fulham's Oscar Bobb giving the visitors an early lead.
Important results: League A: Group 2: Germany 2 (Bischof 39, Wirtz 61) bt Serbia 0; Greece 2 (Ioannidis 23, Masouras 45+2) drew with Netherlands 2 (Van Dijk 59, Reijnders 89). **Group 4:** Denmark 2 (Damsgaard 23, Hojlund 53) lost to Portugal 4 (Cancelo 13, Ramos 25, Vitinha 67, Felix 87); Wales 2 (James 38, Williams 48) bt Norway 1 (Bobb 11). **League B: Group 3:** Republic of Ireland 2 (Parrott 12, 45-pen) drew with Austria 2 (Prass 71, Gregoritsch 77).

Chahal retires from First Class cricket

Leg-spinner Yuzvendra Chahal has announced his retirement from First Class cricket after playing the final English county match for Northamptonshire against Middlesex.
"I played my last First Class match at Lord's, saying these words is emotional as a Test cap was always a dream, one that I carried with me for many years. It may not have happened, but I am genuinely content with the journey I have had. Incredibly grateful for every opportunity that came my way in this format," Chahal posted on Instagram.

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: TNCA league, V-C, GE T&D India vs Bharat Petroleum (Union); MUC vs Ethiraj SA (MIT), 9.30 a.m.

How Hansi flicked the Raphinha switch

The Barcelona coach has unlocked a turbocharged version of the Brazilian attacker by shifting him from the wing to the centre-forward's position. Raphinha has exploded in his new role, rising to the top of the LaLiga scoring charts ahead of Lamine Yamal and Kylian Mbappe



Reuters
Associated Press

The move from the wing to the middle helped Ousmane Dembele assume his final form as an unstoppable force in the 2024-25 season and win the Ballon d'Or.

A similar shift from the flanks to the central spaces as a No. 9 appears to have unleashed a turbocharged version of Raphinha at Barcelona this season. The Brazil international has exploded in his new role, scoring 14 goals in eight matches, 12 in seven games in LaLiga, moving to the top of the scoring charts ahead of Lamine Yamal and Kylian Mbappe.

The striker hunt

Barcelona had spent the close season searching for a centre-forward after Robert Lewandowski left as a free agent for Major League Soccer, with Atletico Madrid's Julian Alvarez and Inter Milan captain Lautaro Martinez high on its list. The summer chase for Alvarez, which developed into a messy saga, ended in frustration for Barcelona, leaving the club short up front.

Barcelona eventually signed Gabriel Jesus as a rotational option for Hansi Flick's squad, but the surprise solution has come from within, with Raphinha moving from his hybrid attacking midfielder-right wing role into the centre-forward position.

"The idea was to bring in a forward with good movement and the ability to link up with others, and Julian [Alvarez] was one such player," said Barcelona sporting director Deco.

"We are happy because we discovered a new face of Raphinha. But more important is that he's happy too. It is different for him, because sometimes he's not in contact with the ball all the time like he used to. He needs to be prepared to attack behind the defenders. We expected that he could do well, but not at this level," Deco added.



GETTY IMAGES

> Yes, I had doubts. People judge you for goals, you're playing as a striker. And then there's the fact that you're playing in the spot where the one and only Robert Lewandowski played
> **RAPHINHA**

Indeed, the change in Raphinha's fortunes at Barcelona has been sudden and spectacular. He was convinced he was leaving two years ago after growing increasingly frustrated under Xavi Hernandez. But Flick's arrival as coach in 2024 proved a turning point: Raphinha, who has thrived under the German, was appointed captain at the start of the season after Ronald Araujo and Marc-Andre ter Stegen left the club and Frenkie de Jong was sidelined by a knee injury.

The coach's belief

In his first conversation with Raphinha, Flick had told the attacker that he believed in his talent. The start of this season has revealed the extent of the coach's belief. Flick had an idea that the 29-year-old's strengths would translate well from the wing to the centre. More to the point, he had the conviction to back his belief.

"In pre-season we did a few tests: the manager liked what he saw and told me a bit about his idea," Raphinha told the *Guardian*. "The adaptation came over the last two years, getting used to coming inside, closer to goal. But we tested [me as] an actual No. 9 and it went well.

> He gives us a lot, his dynamic is top but also without the ball he's good. He has that incredible hunger and intensity, the mentality and attitude we need
> **HANSI FLICK**

"There's the occasional detail that has to be explained, but I'm OK. Before Elche [on the opening day], he asked if I was comfortable there or wanted to go back to my position. I said it was fine, see how it goes, we can always change back."

There has been no reason to change. With 31 goals in seven straight league wins – that's an average of 4.3 goals per match – Barcelona has the hottest attack in Europe, and Raphinha has led the charge in blistering fashion, scoring at will, including back-to-back hat-tricks.

The second of those came in Barcelona's biggest test of the season so far, at the Ramon Sanchez-Pizjuan in the final league fixture before the international break. With his side down a goal to Sevilla after 19 minutes, Raphinha responded in style. He scored a perfect hat-trick, applying three different finishes. All of them would have made the game's top No. 9s proud, for they showcased his skill, instinct, speed and sheer desire to score.

The first goal featured a diagonal in-to-out run onto Andreas Christensen's pass, a tricky feint that put his chasing marker on the ground, and a right-footed finish to the far corner. For the second, he burst out of the defender's blindside to head a Yamal floater expertly. He chipped the keeper off his stronger left foot for the third, this time after an out-to-in run.

"We know the quality of Raphinha," Flick said after the game. "He gives us a lot, his dynamic is top but also without the ball he's good. He has that incredible hunger and intensity, the mentality and attitude we need. After these eight games, I think he's very happy to play as a No. 9."

Interestingly, for someone who has taken to the job like a duck to water, Raphinha wasn't sure at the beginning. "Yes, I had doubts," Raphinha told *Rac+1* when asked about the transition. "Because people judge you for goals, at the end of the day, you're playing as a striker. And then there's the fact that you're playing in the spot where the one and only Robert Lewandowski played. So if you don't score goals, people judge you for that, they demand that from you."

The former Leeds United forward, who joined Barcelona in 2022, has now scored 89 goals in 185 appearances for the Blaugrana, which places him among the top 30 scorers in the club's history. He needs just five more goals to equal the legendary Ronaldinho.

Tellingly, 69 of Raphinha's Barcelona goals have come under Flick, who has led the Catalans to LaLiga titles in each of his two seasons.

"I've always said it and I will always say it, he's the manager that changed both my mentality within the club and also what I thought about myself," Raphinha told *DAZN*. "I'm very grateful for him, and I will demonstrate it whenever I can."

What lies ahead

It's no surprise that the player wants to extend his stay at the club.

"Given the way I've started the season, I think I can keep going for a few more years. I'm in spectacular physical shape so [retirement] is some way off. I would be very happy to extend my contract and, hopefully, finish my career here without having to go elsewhere," Raphinha told *RAC1* radio.

"It's always important to keep in mind that you need to improve in some areas. I'll never say I'm at my peak, because I always try to improve as much as I can. There's surely something more I can contribute to the team than what I'm currently giving."

It will be interesting to see just how Raphinha's time at No. 9 plays out. Will he have a season for the ages like Dembele did and maybe even enjoy a late-career swing as an elite striker? Or will it be no more than a short-term fix, even if it is successful?

All we know for sure is that Raphinha, like he has through his career, will give it everything.

STACKING UP



ATP Men's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Jannik Sinner	25	11,000	16
2	Alexander Zverev	29	9,630	19
3	Carlos Alcaraz	23	5,060	16
4	Ben Shelton	23	4,680	22
5	Felix Auger-Aliassime	26	3,890	22
6	Daniil Medvedev	30	3,710	23
7	Flavio Cobolli	24	3,680	25
8	Frances Tiafoe	28	3,380	21
9	Arthur Fils	22	3,150	18
10	Alex de Minaur	27	3,150	23
11	Novak Djokovic	39	2,980	15
12	Taylor Fritz	28	2,880	21
13	Rafael Jodar	20	2,659	21
14	Jakub Mensik	21	2,405	20
15	Learner Tien	20	2,395	20

Top Indians ▶



Sumit Nagal
Rank 249 ▼ 1 spot



Dhakshineswar Suresh
Rank 364 ▼ 5 spots

WTA Women's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Elena Rybakina	27	9,901	21
2	Aryna Sabalenka	28	7,810	20
3	Jessica Pegula	32	7,265	19
4	Coco Gauff	22	7,244	19
5	Mirra Andreeva	19	5,841	21
6	Linda Noskova	21	5,328	20
7	Elina Svitolina	32	4,809	17
8	Karolina Muchova	30	4,683	20
9	Iga Swiatek	25	4,119	19
10	Marta Kostyuk	24	4,040	18
11	Amanda Anisimova	25	3,363	15
12	Belinda Bencic	29	2,925	19
13	Iva Jovic	18	2,841	23
14	Diana Shnaider	22	2,588	23
15	Victoria Mboko	20	2,521	19

Top Indians ▶



Sahaja Yamalapalli
Rank 354 ▼ 5 spots



Vaishnavi Adkar
Rank 374 ▼ 13 spots



F1 Drivers' standings

#	Driver	Team	Points	Wins
1	A.K. Antonelli	Mercedes	302	8
2	G. Russell	Mercedes	236	3
3	L. Hamilton	Ferrari	199	1
4	L. Norris	McLaren	186	2
5	C. Leclerc	Ferrari	179	1
6	M. Verstappen	Red Bull	163	0
7	O. Piastri	McLaren	120	0
8	I. Hadjar	Red Bull	86	0
9	L. Lawson	RB	59	0
10	P. Gasly	Alpine	41	0
11	A. Lindblad	RB	37	0
12	F. Colapinto	Alpine	27	0
13	O. Bearman	Haas	20	0
14	G. Bortoleto	Audi	10	0
15	N. Hulkenberg	Audi	7	0
16	E. Ocon	Haas	7	0
17	C. Sainz	Williams	7	0
18	A. Albon	Williams	5	0
19	F. Alonso	Aston Martin	3	0
20	Y. Tsunoda	RB	1	0
21	V. Bottas	Cadillac	0	0
22	S. Perez	Cadillac	0	0
23	L. Stroll	Aston Martin	0	0



A.K. Antonelli



G. Russell

F1 Constructors' standings

Pos	Team	Points	Wins
1	Mercedes	538	11
2	Ferrari	378	2
3	McLaren	306	2
4	Red Bull	263	0
5	RB	83	0
6	Alpine	68	0
7	Haas	27	0
8	Audi	17	0
9	Williams	12	0
10	Aston Martin	3	0
11	Cadillac	0	0



Badminton Men's ranking

#	Player	Points	Events
1	Kunlavut Vitidsarn	86,915	16
2	Christo Popov	86,632	19
3	Jonatan Christie	84,431	16
4	Shi Yu Qi	84,075	13
5	Chou Tien Chen	83,680	25
6	Anders Antonsen	83,655	16
7	Kodai Naraoka	77,540	18
8	Alex Lanier	76,985	15
9	Victor Lai	76,465	17
10	Alwi Farhan	70,099	16
11	Lin Chun-Yi	64,924	17
12	Li Shi Feng	64,533	15
13	Loh Kean Yew	63,140	18
14	Lakshya Sen	62,813	20
15	Toma Junior Popov	62,697	19

Top Indians ▶



Lakshya Sen
Rank 14



Ayush Shetty
Rank 20

Badminton Women's ranking

#	Player	Points	Events
1	An Se Young	1,21,287	14
2	Wang Zhi Yi	1,03,989	15
3	Akane Yamaguchi	1,02,576	17
4	Chen Yu Fei	86,651	14
5	Ratchanok Intanon	74,606	19
6	Putri Kusuma Wardani	71,603	16
7	Tomoka Miyazaki	71,456	20
8	Han Yue	69,008	12
9	Pornpawee Chochuwong	66,927	14
10	Nozomi Okuhara	64,160	17
11	P.V. Sindhu	64,151	12
12	Kim Ga Eun	59,041	15
13	Line Christophersen	57,940	21
14	Michelle Li	55,327	20
15	Mia Blichfeldt	54,483	11

Top Indians ▶



P.V. Sindhu
Rank 11



Unnati Hooda
Rank 24



Test Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Harry Brook	861	898
2	Steve Smith	840	947
3	Joe Root	816	932
4	Travis Head	811	884
5	Temba Bavuma	775	806
6	Rachin Ravindra	740	740
7	Rishabh Pant	713	801
8	Daryl Mitchell	710	804
9	Shubman Gill	709	807
10	Kamindu Mendis	706	784

Test Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Mitchell Starc	872	872
2	Matt Henry	861	870
3	Ollie Robinson	856	856
4	Jasprit Bumrah	853	908
5	Pat Cummins	841	914
6	Marco Jansen	825	825
7	Kagiso Rabada	807	902
8	Scott Boland	804	820
9	Josh Hazlewood	783	864
10	Noman Ali	777	853

ODI Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Shubman Gill	816	841
2	Virat Kohli	796	908
3	Daryl Mitchell	794	840
4	Rohit Sharma	753	879
5	Ibrahim Zadran	719	756
6	Babar Azam	689	894
7	Kusal Mendis	674	675
8	Shai Hope	673	782
9	Joe Root	660	810
10	Harry Tector	653	730

ODI Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	714	775
2	Abrar Ahmed	675	675
3	Keshav Maharaj	667	737
4	Mitchell Santner	644	656
5	Kuldeep Yadav	623	757
6	Maheesh Theekshana	622	680
7	Jofra Archer	617	682
8	Shaheen Afridi	604	691
9	Mehidy Hasan	602	722
10	Josh Hazlewood	591	725

T20I Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Ishan Kishan	892	910
2	Abhishek Sharma	887	931
3	Sahibzada Farhan	848	848
4	Harry Brook	793	793
5	Jos Buttler	789	794
5	Dewald Brevis	789	806
7	Phil Salt	775	881
8	Pathum Nissanka	757	796
9	Tilak Varma	719	845
10	Mitchell Marsh	706	706

T20I Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Abrar Ahmed	736	757
2	Rashid Khan	720	828
3	Adam Zampa	700	746
4	Adil Rashid	695	747
5	Nathan Ellis	675	678
6	Jamie Overton	674	674
7	Varun Chakaravarthy	665	818
8	Mohammad Nawaz	658	672
9	Wanindu Hasaranga	656	809
10	Liam Dawson	648	652

I can say that my only student is contesting the World title match

Fresh off his success in the Global Chess League, B. Adhiban talks about working as a coach while still being an active player. Having guided Vaishali to Candidates glory, he previews her chances against champion Ju Wenjun. He also reveals why he thinks Gukesh is the favourite against Sindarov and offers an insight into Ganges Grandmasters' triumph in the GCL



B. VELANKANNI RAJ

INTERVIEW

B. Adhiban

P.K. Ajith Kumar

It was a memorable debut as a coach for B. Adhiban at the Tech Mahindra Global Chess League in Bengaluru last month. He guided Ganges Grandmasters to a maiden title in the world's most glamorous chess league. Nicknamed 'The Beast', he was a part of the Indian teams that won the bronze medal at the Chess Olympiads in 2014 and 2022. Excerpts from an interview Adhiban gave *The Hindu*:

What made you accept the offer to coach Ganges Grandmasters at such short notice?

Manu Gurtu of MGD1 is my manager, and I know the company's Sreekar Channapragada, too. They took over ownership of Ganges Grandmasters and when they offered me the job, I thought it would be interesting. My only condition was that it shouldn't clash with my playing schedule.

I joined the team on the eve of the auction. There was one player Manu wanted: Levon Aronian. I also wanted him. Apparently, other teams, too. I was happy that we got him; he is an excellent team player. He can lift the team when it is down.

His sense of humour helps, too...

Yes. And I have liked him as a player for a long time, since the time he won the World junior championship. Another player we really wanted in our team was Nihal Sarin. I am also glad that we got Ian [Nepomniachtchi]. He is a fantastic player. And he gave us that crucial win in the final against Magnus Carlsen [APL Alpine Pipers].

The two women in your team, Polina Shuvalova and Stavroula Tsolakidou, did a great job. Aronian called them your secret weapon and said he didn't expect them to do so well.

> If there is one player who could beat Ju Wenjun, I think it is Vaishali. There aren't too many players like Vaishali at the top level in women's chess

Manu wanted to retain both of them. They had played well last year. Polina, I knew personally that she was a very fast player.

She was brilliant here. She made probably the biggest contribution, overall, to your team...

Yeah, exactly. Because she gave us a very good start, actually. And even when the team was not doing well, she was doing well. Yes, she was someone whom you could always count on. She plays fearlessly; she is not afraid of anyone. In fact, I was expecting that she would win the Player-of-the-Tournament award.



GCL

Which went to Stavroula. She thanked you in public, and even handed her Player-of-the-Match award to you on the stage...

That was very touching. Polina already had her own set of ideas. But I did work with Stavi quite a lot, especially in opening preparations. She is an excellent student with an amazing memory.

Whatever I suggested during the training, she would replicate on the board. The openings she played here were mostly new for her. We were just improvising during the tournament. We were preparing together every day for at least an hour and a half.

Were there games that went according to the plan more or less?

Well, there was this game with Koneru Humpy in the match against Alpine Pipers. The opening went according to our plan. In the final, against Nino [Batsiashvili] too, it was my idea that she implemented over the board.

And Batsiashvili has been mighty good at the GCL.

Yes. I wanted Stavi to beat her, so that she could prove she could beat everyone.

So you must be pleased that you could play a role in the progress of a player.

Yes, because this is what coaching is all about, right?

And this was your first proper stint as a coach, though you worked with R. Vaishali before she played in the Candidates, which she went on to win, much against the odds.

Yes, I could say that my only student is contesting the World championship match.

How do you view Vaishali's chances in that World title match against Ju Wenjun?

She didn't have a good Olympiad at Samarkand. I don't really know what happened. I will talk to her when she comes back. As for the World championship, if there is one player who could beat Ju Wenjun, I think it is Vaishali.

She should play freely, and not worry too much about the result: she shouldn't think, 'What will happen if I don't win'. There aren't too many players like Vaishali at the top level in women's chess, the players who could challenge men, like Judit Polgar or Hou Yifan. Whenever I play against Vaishali, I feel I have to be a bit careful. I don't get that feeling when I meet other female players.

She plays aggressively and fearlessly. She is a bit like Judit in that regard, and rather unlike Hou Yifan. Among the Chinese women, Lei Tingjie, I feel, is the most aggressive player.

Vaishali has to be cautious against Ju Wenjun. She is difficult to beat and not someone who will collapse. I remember the way she [Ju] beat Vidit Gujrathi, someone who resembles her in style. If you can beat a strong player who is very close to your style, it means something.

Talking of World championships, your thoughts on the match between D. Gukesh and Javokhir Sindarov? Not many people are betting on the reigning World champion as he hasn't been in good form after winning the title in 2024.

Well, I believe Gukesh has excellent chances. The way he played at the Olympiad [where he won a silver on the fourth board] should help his confidence. I think the thing is, he should not try to go back to who he was [when he was doing incredible things like winning gold on the top board in successive Olympiads]. He should just find a new version of himself. He has changed a lot and now so many things are different. He has to rediscover himself.

Gukesh is someone who has risen above the expectations. Whatever hurdle you throw at him, he will cross that. A few years back, me and Anish [Giri] had this running joke. When Gukesh was doing so well in classical chess, we would say, 'Okay at least he is bad at rapid chess'. Then he ended up winning some rapid games somewhere. Anish and I now said, 'At least he is still bad at blitz'. Then he won against [Vladimir] Kramnik in Armageddon. Then, after crossing 2700 [Elo points], he came below that. Now we said, 'Maybe he is not 2700 level yet'. Then he comes to the Olympiad and destroys everyone. The moment you think he is done or he is not ready for something, he always proves himself.

Sindarov has been in great form. But when it comes to the peaks of their chess, I feel Gukesh is better than Sindarov. I may be biased, but my favourite for the World title this year is Gukesh.

GAME THEORY

Premier League: goals vs. expected goals

Brighton has generated the most expected goals (xG) and outperformed this metric to lead the Premier League's goal-scoring chart in the opening rounds of the season. Sunderland and Manchester United come in next on xG, but have scored fewer goals than expected, based on the shot opportunities they have had. A look at how the teams in the English top division rank on xG and the margin between the goals they have scored and the xG they have generated (xGDiff):


PASCAL GROSS (BRIGHTON)


BRIAN BROBBEY (SUNDERLAND)


BRUNO FERNANDES (MAN. UNITED)

Rank	Team	xG	Goals	xGDiff
1	Brighton	12.48	14	1.52
2	Sunderland	10.81	6	-4.81
3	Man. United	10.24	7	-3.24
4	Man. City	10.16	13	2.84
5	Brentford	9.84	10	0.16
6	Bournemouth	9.08	5	-4.08
7	Arsenal	8.85	8	-0.85
8	N. Forest	8.76	4	-4.76
9	Chelsea	8.42	10	1.58
10	Liverpool	8.04	7	-1.04
11	Everton	7.74	6	-1.74
12	Fulham	7.74	4	-3.74
13	C. Palace	7.45	5	-2.45
14	Leeds	7.06	6	-1.06
15	Ipswich	6.91	7	0.09
16	Hull	5.97	6	0.03
17	Tottenham	5.91	2	-3.91
18	Newcastle	5.7	9	3.3
19	Coventry	5	1	-4
20	Aston Villa	5	4	-1

SOURCE: WHOSCORED.COM

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Bridge view

The Rolex Big Boat Series, hosted by the historic St. Francis Yacht Club in San Francisco every September, is more than a marquee regatta.

Since its inception six decades ago, it has been viewed as a standard-bearer, showcasing as it does top talent on the water and boats from around the world. It is also certified as a platinum-level clean regatta since it meets certain sustainability standards.

The event has a unique selling point: the scenic red towers of the Golden Gate Bridge act as a backdrop for some thrilling finishes.

The St. Francis Yacht Club, founded in 1927, welcomed eight yachts to the edge of the city's Marina district in 1964 for the inaugural Perpetual Trophy Regatta, which in time evolved into the Rolex Big Boat Series.

This year's edition, the 62nd, brought 81 boats and 700 sailors to the pretty venue, doubling as the 2026 ORC North American Championship.

It also featured the returning Classics division, which had boats such as the Ocean Queen V, a 75-year-old wooden yawl that serves as an educational aid for young sailors when it isn't racing.